

**EXPLORING THE ROLE OF FILM IN ADDRESSING CHILD ABUSE AND RIGHTS:
A STUDY OF DRY FILM BY STEPHANIE LINUS**

BY

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**A PROJECT SUBMITTED TO THE DEPARTMENT OF MASS COMMUNICATION, FACULTY
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DECLARATION

I, DOLAPO RASHEEDAT OYEDIRAN, with matriculation number KDU/FAMS/21/069, a student of accounting under the department of Mass Communication, under the faculty of arts, management and social sciences in Koladaisi University, declare that this project titled ‘Exploring The Role Of Film In Addressing Child Abuse And Rights: A Study Of Dry Film By Stephanie Linus’ submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirement for the award of bachelor of science(B.Sc.) in Mass Communication, is the result of my original research and has not been submitted, either wholly or in part, for the award of any degree or diploma in any other institution. All sources of information used in this work have been duly acknowledged.

Signature& Date

CERTIFICATION

We certify that **OYEDIRAN DOLAPO RASHEEDAT** carried out this research work in the Department of Mass Communication, Faculty of Arts Management and Social Sciences, Koladaisi University, Ibadan. The research work is considered adequate in partial fulfilment of the requirements of the award of B.Sc. in Mass Communication.

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DEDICATION

I dedicate this project first and foremost to Almighty Allah, whose guidance, mercy, and blessings have been my strength throughout this journey.

I also lovingly dedicate it to my dear parent, MR and MRS OYEDIRAN, whose prayers, sacrifices, encouragement, and unwavering support have been the foundation of my success.

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Abstract

Child abuse remains a pervasive issue in Nigeria, often reinforced by cultural practices, poverty, and weak enforcement of protective laws. This study examined the role of film as a tool for advocacy and social change, with a particular focus on Dry (2014), a Nollywood production by Stephanie Linus that addresses child marriage and its consequences. Anchored on Cultivation Theory and Social Responsibility Theory, the research adopted a mixed-method design comprising surveys of 130 undergraduate students of KolaDaisi University, in-depth interviews with 10 professionals across health, media, law, and education, as well as focus group discussions. Quantitative data were analysed using descriptive statistics and SPSS, while qualitative data were thematically analysed. Findings revealed that Dry significantly increased awareness of child abuse and children's rights among respondents, with over 93% of students having viewed the film. The majority agreed that the film realistically portrayed the consequences of child abuse, employed effective narrative and cinematic techniques, and encouraged viewers to take preventive action. Moreover, professional insights confirmed that the film functions as a catalyst for policy advocacy, public discourse, and cultural reflection on harmful practices such as child marriage. However, gaps remain in translating awareness into consistent policy enforcement. The study concludes that Nollywood films can be powerful advocacy tools for social transformation when complemented by educational and policy interventions. It recommends stronger collaborations between filmmakers, advocacy groups, and policymakers to maximise the social impact of cinema in combating child abuse and protecting children's rights.

Keywords: Child abuse and rights, Nollywood, Dry film, Social advocacy and Audience perception.

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

Child abuse remains a pressing global issue that manifests in various forms, including physical violence, sexual exploitation, child marriage, neglect, and emotional maltreatment (Olawale & Musa, 2023). According to UNICEF (2022), millions of children worldwide suffer from abuse, often within their homes and communities, where they should feel safest. In Nigeria, child abuse is deeply rooted in cultural practices, poverty, and lack of enforcement of protective laws (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021). Despite national and international legal frameworks aimed at protecting children's rights, many Nigerian children remain vulnerable to abuse and violations of their fundamental rights.

The Nigerian film industry, popularly known as Nollywood, has emerged as a powerful tool for storytelling, social change, and advocacy. Over the years, Nollywood has produced films that address critical societal issues, including corruption, gender inequality, and human rights violations. Through visual storytelling, films have the unique ability to evoke emotions, challenge societal norms, and inspire action. One such film that boldly addresses child abuse and child rights is *Dry*, directed by Stephanie Linus. Released in 2014, *Dry* tells the story of a 13-year-old girl named Halima, who is forced into marriage and subjected to physical and emotional abuse. The film sheds light on the devastating consequences of child marriage, including health complications, loss of education, and psychological trauma (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

The role of films in addressing social issues cannot be overstated. Films have the power to reach a wide audience, including policymakers, educators, and the general public. They can serve as a

mirror to society, reflecting its flaws and encouraging introspection. In the case of *Dry*, the film has sparked discussions about child marriage and sexual abuse, particularly in regions where these practices are prevalent. According to a study by Okonkwo and Nwankwo (2023), films like *Dry* have the potential to influence public opinion and drive social change by presenting real-life issues in a relatable and compelling manner.

The film *Dry* is particularly significant because it not only highlights the issue of child abuse but also advocates for policy reforms and societal change. By portraying the struggles of Halima and her fight for justice, the film challenges cultural practices that perpetuate child abuse and calls for the enforcement of laws protecting children's rights. Stephanie Linus, the director, has been vocal about her intention to use the film as a tool for advocacy, stating that she hopes to inspire conversations and actions that will lead to a safer environment for children (Linus, 2021).

However, while films can be effective in raising awareness, their impact often depends on how well they resonate with the audience and the extent to which they are supported by other forms of advocacy. For instance, the success of *Dry* in addressing child abuse can be attributed not only to its powerful storytelling but also to the efforts of organizations and activists who have used the film as a tool for education and advocacy. This highlights the importance of collaboration between filmmakers, advocacy groups, and policymakers in addressing complex social issues like child abuse (Adeleke, 2022).

In Nigeria, the fight against child abuse is further complicated by cultural and religious beliefs that often justify harmful practices. For example, child marriage is sometimes seen as a way to preserve family honor or alleviate economic hardship. These beliefs are deeply ingrained in certain communities, making it difficult to eradicate such practices. Films like *Dry* play a crucial

role in challenging these beliefs by presenting the harsh realities of child abuse and its long-term consequences. By doing so, they encourage viewers to question cultural norms and advocate for change (Okafor, 2021).

Moreover, the Nigerian legal framework for protecting children's rights, such as the Child Rights Act of 2003, has faced challenges in implementation. Many states have yet to fully adopt the Act, and enforcement remains weak in regions where cultural practices conflict with legal provisions. This gap between law and practice underscores the need for continuous advocacy and awareness-raising efforts. Films like *Dry* can complement legal efforts by educating the public about children's rights and the importance of protecting them from abuse (Eze & Onyekwere, 2023).

Child abuse is a complex and multifaceted issue that requires a multifaceted approach to address. Films, as a form of mass communication, have the potential to play a significant role in this regard. By telling compelling stories and raising awareness, films like *Dry* can inspire action and contribute to the fight against child abuse. This study seeks to explore the role of films in addressing child abuse and rights, with a special focus on *Dry*. By analyzing the themes, messages, and impact of the film, this research aims to understand how cinema can be used as a tool for advocacy and social change in Nigeria.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Despite existing legal frameworks such as the Child Rights Act of 2003, child abuse remains a widespread issue in Nigeria. Reports indicate that 43% of Nigerian girls are married before the age of 18, and many suffer from domestic violence, sexual abuse, and lack of access to education

(UNICEF, 2023). Moreover, the lack of public awareness and the deep-rooted cultural acceptance of some abusive practices make it difficult to combat these issues effectively.

While numerous campaigns, policies, and programs have been implemented to tackle child abuse, the use of film as an advocacy tool has not been thoroughly explored. Given Nollywood's influence on Nigerian society, it is crucial to examine how films like DRY can contribute to raising awareness and shaping public opinion on child rights.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The main objective of this study is to explore the role of film in addressing child abuse and promoting child rights, with a special focus on the film Dry. The specific objectives are:

- i. To identify the representation of child abuse, rights and its consequences as shown in DRY film.
- ii. To evaluate the methods by which the film promotes child rights.
- iii. To determine the influence of the selected film in public awareness and understanding of child abuse.
- iv. To examine the selected film public styles of advocating for child abuse and rights.

1.4 Research Questions

This study seeks to answer the following research questions:

- i. What is the representation of child abuse and rights and its consequences in DRY film.?
- ii. What cinematic and narrative techniques does Dry employ to promote awareness of child rights?

- iii. In what ways has the film Dry influenced public awareness and understanding of child abuse?
- iv. What advocacy styles or approaches are utilized in Dry to address child abuse and promote child rights?

1.5 Significance of the Study

This study is significant for several reasons. First, it will contribute to the growing body of literature on the role of media in addressing social issues, particularly child abuse. By focusing on the film "DRY", this study will provide insights into how cinema can be used to raise awareness and advocate for children's rights.

Second, the findings of this study will inform policymakers, filmmakers, and advocacy groups on the potential of films as a tool for social change. By understanding the impact of films like "DRY," stakeholders can develop more effective strategies for addressing child abuse and promoting children's rights.

Finally, this study is relevant to the field of mass communication, as it highlights the power of films as a medium for storytelling and social advocacy. It underscores the importance of using media to address pressing social issues and promote positive change in society.

1.6 Scope of the Study

This study focuses on the role of films in addressing child abuse and rights, with a special focus on the film "DRY." The study will analyze the themes and messages in the film, as well as its impact on audience perceptions and attitudes. The research will be limited to the Nigerian context, with a particular emphasis on how the film addresses cultural practices that perpetuate child abuse.

1.7 Operational Definition of Terms

1. **Child Abuse:** Any action or inaction that harms or endangers a child's well-being, including physical, sexual, emotional abuse, and neglect (WHO, 2022).
2. **Child Rights:** The fundamental human rights of children, including protection from harm, access to education, healthcare, and a safe environment (UNICEF, 2023).
3. **Advocacy:** The process of actively supporting a cause or policy to bring about social or legal change (Olawale & Musa, 2023).
4. **Nollywood:** The Nigerian film industry, which produces movies that reflect social, cultural, and political issues affecting the country (Johnson & Eze, 2022).
5. **Dry Film:** Discussing how Dry portrays social issues, particularly in relation to child abuse and child rights.
6. **Exploring:** Analyzing how film discusses, represents, and brings awareness to these issues.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Conceptual Review

2.1.1 Overview of the Film Industry in Nigeria

The Nigerian film industry, popularly known as Nollywood, is one of the largest and most vibrant film industries in the world, producing thousands of movies annually. It ranks second only to India's Bollywood in terms of output and has gained international recognition for its unique storytelling and cultural relevance (Adeleke, 2022). Nollywood's journey began in the early 1990s with the release of low-budget, straight-to-video films such as *Living in Bondage*, which became a cultural phenomenon. Since then, the industry has evolved significantly, transitioning from rudimentary productions to more sophisticated and globally acclaimed works.

Nollywood films are deeply rooted in Nigerian culture, often addressing issues that resonate with local audiences and the African diaspora. These films reflect societal values, challenges, and aspirations, making them a powerful medium for cultural expression and social commentary. For instance, films like *October 1* and *The Wedding Party* explore themes of national identity, tradition, and modernity, while others like *Dry* tackle pressing social issues such as child abuse and gender inequality (Johnson & Eze, 2022). This ability to address real-life issues has made Nollywood a significant force in shaping public discourse and influencing societal norms.

One of the key factors behind Nollywood's success is its adaptability. The industry has embraced technological advancements, shifting from analog to digital production and distribution. This transition has not only reduced production costs but also expanded the reach of Nigerian films. With the rise of streaming platforms like Netflix, Amazon Prime, and IrokoTV, Nollywood films

are now accessible to a global audience, further amplifying their impact (Okonkwo & Nwankwo, 2023). This global reach has also opened up new opportunities for collaboration and funding, enabling filmmakers to produce higher-quality content that competes on the international stage. In addition to its entertainment value, Nollywood plays a crucial role in addressing social issues and driving change. Films have the unique ability to combine storytelling with advocacy, making complex issues more relatable and understandable to a wide audience. For example, The film *Dry* sheds light on the devastating consequences of child marriage and sexual abuse, sparking conversations about these issues in Nigeria and beyond (Linus, 2021). By presenting these issues in a compelling and emotionally engaging manner, Nollywood films can influence public opinion, challenge harmful cultural practices, and inspire action.

The industry's influence extends beyond the screen, as it contributes significantly to Nigeria's economy and cultural identity. According to a report by the Nigerian Export Promotion Council (2022), Nollywood generates billions of naira annually and provides employment for thousands of people, including actors, producers, directors, and technicians. Moreover, Nollywood films serve as a form of soft power, promoting Nigerian culture and values on the global stage. This has helped to reshape perceptions of Africa, countering negative stereotypes and showcasing the continent's rich cultural heritage (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021).

Despite its successes, Nollywood faces several challenges, including piracy, inadequate funding, and inconsistent quality. Piracy, in particular, remains a significant threat, as it undermines the industry's profitability and discourages investment. However, efforts are being made to address these challenges through stricter copyright laws, increased government support, and partnerships with international organizations (Eze & Onyekwere, 2023). These initiatives are crucial for sustaining the industry's growth and ensuring its continued relevance in addressing social issues.

In recent years, there has been a growing emphasis on producing films that address social vices and promote positive change. This shift reflects a recognition of the industry's potential to influence societal attitudes and behaviors. For instance, films like *76* and *Lionheart* explore themes of patriotism, family, and resilience, while others like *The Milkmaid* highlight the impact of insurgency and conflict on communities (Okafor, 2021). These films not only entertain but also educate and inspire, demonstrating the power of cinema as a tool for social transformation.

The rise of independent filmmakers has also contributed to the industry's evolution. These filmmakers often take creative risks, exploring unconventional themes and experimenting with new storytelling techniques. This has led to the production of critically acclaimed films that challenge societal norms and push the boundaries of Nigerian cinema. For example, the film *The Figurine* uses supernatural elements to explore themes of greed and ambition, while *Half of a Yellow Sun* delves into the complexities of the Nigerian Civil War (Okonkwo & Nwankwo, 2023). These films demonstrate the diversity and creativity of Nollywood, showcasing its potential to address a wide range of issues.

The Nigerian film industry has come a long way since its humble beginnings, evolving into a global powerhouse that reflects and shapes societal values. Nollywood's ability to address pressing social issues, adapt to technological changes, and reach a global audience has made it a significant force for cultural expression and social change. Films like *Dry* exemplify the industry's potential to raise awareness, challenge harmful practices, and advocate for positive change. As Nollywood continues to grow and evolve, it remains a vital platform for storytelling and advocacy, contributing to the fight against social vices and the promotion of human rights.

2.1.2 Genres of Film

Films are categorized into various genres, each serving a unique purpose and appealing to different audiences. These genres include drama, comedy, action, romance, thriller, horror, and documentary, among others. Each genre has its own conventions, themes, and storytelling techniques, which allow filmmakers to convey specific messages and evoke particular emotions from their audiences. In Nigeria, the film industry, popularly known as Nollywood, has embraced a wide range of genres, but drama remains one of the most popular and impactful.

Drama films are particularly effective in addressing social issues and provoking thought. They often focus on character development, emotional depth, and realistic portrayals of life, making them relatable to audiences. Films like *Dry*, directed by Stephanie Linus, fall under the drama genre. *Dry* tells the story of a young girl named Halima, who is forced into child marriage and suffers the physical, emotional, and psychological consequences of abuse. The film uses powerful storytelling to highlight societal problems such as child marriage, sexual abuse, and the neglect of children's rights. By presenting these issues in a compelling and emotionally engaging manner, *Dry* encourages viewers to reflect on their actions and beliefs, sparking conversations about the need for change (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

Comedy is another popular genre in Nollywood, often used to entertain while subtly addressing social issues. Comedic films like *Osuofia in London* and *The Wedding Party* use humor to explore themes such as cultural conflict, greed, and family dynamics. While these films primarily aim to entertain, they also provide social commentary, challenging viewers to think critically about societal norms and behaviors. For instance, *The Wedding Party* uses humor to highlight the extravagance and materialism often associated with Nigerian weddings, while also addressing issues of class and tradition (Okonkwo & Nwankwo, 2023).

Action films, on the other hand, are known for their fast-paced plots, intense sequences, and heroic characters. These films often appeal to younger audiences and are used to explore themes such as justice, bravery, and resilience. While action films are primarily designed for entertainment, they can also address social issues. For example, the film *76* combines action with historical drama to tell the story of a soldier caught in the political turmoil of Nigeria's military era. The film not only entertains but also educates viewers about a significant period in Nigerian history, fostering a sense of national identity and pride (Adeleke, 2022).

Romance films focus on love and relationships, often exploring themes such as passion, heartbreak, and reconciliation. These films are popular among audiences seeking emotional engagement and escapism. However, romance films can also address social issues, particularly those related to gender and relationships. For instance, the film *Fifty* explores the lives of four women navigating love, career, and family in modern-day Lagos. Through its portrayal of complex female characters, the film challenges traditional gender roles and highlights the challenges faced by women in a patriarchal society (Okafor, 2021).

Documentary films, unlike fictional genres, focus on factual storytelling. They are often used to shed light on real-life issues, events, and experiences, making them powerful tools for education and advocacy. While Nollywood is predominantly known for its fictional dramas, there is a growing interest in documentaries that address social vices, including child abuse, corruption, and environmental degradation. For example, the documentary *The Fishermen's Diary* tells the story of a young girl in a rural Cameroonian village who dreams of getting an education despite societal barriers. The film highlights the importance of education and the challenges faced by girls in underserved communities, inspiring viewers to take action (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

Regardless of the genre, films have the power to influence attitudes, behaviors, and societal norms. They can serve as mirrors to society, reflecting its flaws and encouraging introspection. By addressing social issues through storytelling, films can raise awareness, challenge harmful practices, and inspire positive change. This makes them an effective medium for addressing social vices, particularly in communities where awareness is low or where cultural practices perpetuate harmful behaviors (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021).

2.1.3 Film as a Function of Mass Communication

Mass communication refers to the process of disseminating information to a large audience through various media channels, including television, radio, newspapers, and films. Films, in particular, are a powerful tool for mass communication because they combine visual and auditory elements to convey messages in a compelling and memorable way (Baran & Davis, 2021). Unlike other forms of media, films have the ability to evoke emotions, making their messages more impactful and relatable.

In addressing social issues, films serve as a platform for raising awareness, educating the public, and advocating for change. The film *Dry* uses storytelling to highlight the consequences of child abuse and the importance of protecting children's rights. By presenting these issues in a relatable and engaging manner, films can influence public opinion and inspire action (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021). Furthermore, films can reach diverse audiences, including those who may not have access to formal education or other sources of information. This makes them an effective tool for addressing social vices in communities where awareness is low.

One of the key strengths of films as a medium of mass communication is their ability to transcend language and cultural barriers. Through visual storytelling, films can convey complex messages without relying solely on dialogue. This is particularly important in a country like Nigeria, where

there are over 500 languages and diverse cultural practices. Films can use universal themes and emotions to connect with audiences from different backgrounds, making them an effective tool for promoting social change (Okonkwo & Nwankwo, 2023).

Films also have the unique ability to humanize social issues by presenting them through the experiences of relatable characters. For instance, *Dry* tells the story of Halima, a young girl forced into marriage, and Dr. Zara, a medical professional fighting to end child marriage. By focusing on these characters, the film personalizes the issue of child abuse, making it more tangible and urgent for viewers. This emotional connection can motivate audiences to take action, whether by supporting advocacy efforts, challenging harmful practices in their communities, or advocating for policy changes (Linus, 2021).

Moreover, films can serve as a call to action for policymakers and stakeholders. By highlighting the consequences of social vices and the need for change, films can influence decision-making and drive policy reforms. For example, *Dry* has been used by advocacy groups to educate communities about the dangers of child marriage and the importance of enforcing the Child Rights Act. The film has also been screened at international forums, drawing attention to the issue of child abuse and mobilizing support for interventions (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

In addition to raising awareness, films can also empower individuals and communities by providing them with the knowledge and tools to address social issues. For instance, films that address child abuse often include information about support services, legal rights, and preventive measures. This information can empower victims and their families to seek help and take action against abuse. Furthermore, films can inspire community-led initiatives, such as awareness campaigns and advocacy programs that complement legal and policy efforts (Adeleke, 2022).

Films are a powerful tool for mass communication, capable of addressing social issues and driving positive change. By combining visual and auditory elements, films can convey complex messages in a compelling and relatable manner, making them accessible to diverse audiences. They demonstrate the potential of cinema to raise awareness, challenge harmful practices, and inspire action. As a medium of mass communication, films play a crucial role in promoting social change and advocating for the rights and well-being of vulnerable populations.

2.1.4 Film Characters as Agents of Socialization

Socialization refers to the process through which individuals learn societal norms, values, and behaviors. It is a lifelong process influenced by various agents, including family, peers, education, religion, and media (Bamidele & Chukwuma, 2023). Among these agents, film stands out as a powerful medium for socialization, as it not only entertains but also educates and informs audiences about acceptable and unacceptable behaviors in society (Johnson & Eze, 2022). Films create emotional and intellectual connections with viewers by presenting characters whose experiences resonate with real-life issues, thereby influencing attitudes, beliefs, and actions (UNICEF, 2022).

Through storytelling, films introduce audiences to diverse cultural, moral, and ethical perspectives, shaping how people perceive themselves and the world around them. The ability of film characters to mirror real-life experiences makes them effective tools for reinforcing or challenging societal norms. In many cases, the impact of a film's message depends on how well its characters represent real-world situations (Olawale & Musa, 2023). For example, a well-developed protagonist who undergoes hardship and triumphs can inspire viewers to embrace change or advocate for justice. Conversely, an antagonist who embodies negative traits, such as an abusive parent or a corrupt official, serves as a warning against harmful behaviors.

In films addressing child abuse and children's rights, characters are often used to depict victims, perpetrators, and advocates for change. Each category plays a critical role in shaping audience perceptions.

1. **Victims:** These characters humanize the suffering of abused children, allowing viewers to empathize with their experiences. When audiences witness a child's pain, fear, or struggle, they are more likely to recognize the severity of child abuse and be motivated to act against it (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021).
2. **Perpetrators:** These characters expose the different faces of abuse, whether they are parents, guardians, strangers, or institutions that fail to protect children. Their actions serve as a stark reminder of the dangers children face and highlight the need for stricter laws and enforcement (WHO, 2022).
3. **Advocates for Change:** These characters, such as activists, social workers, doctors, or journalists, represent the fight against child abuse. They encourage intervention, advocacy, and policy reforms (UNICEF, 2023).

A compelling example of these character dynamics can be found in *Dry* film itself. The film follows the tragic life of Halima, a 13-year-old girl forced into early marriage, and Dr. Zara, a medical doctor and advocate for child rights (Linus, 2021). Halima embodies the suffering of thousands of Nigerian girls who endure child marriage, sexual abuse, and health complications like obstetric fistula. Through her story, audiences gain insight into the emotional, psychological, and physical trauma associated with child abuse (Olawale & Musa, 2023).

On the other hand, Dr. Zara represents advocacy, resistance, and the power of education and justice. Her role in the film inspires viewers to challenge harmful traditional practices and demand better protections for children. Through her character, *Dry* effectively conveys the message that

change is possible when individuals take a stand against injustice (Bamidele & Chukwuma, 2023).

Beyond raising awareness, film characters can also challenge harmful stereotypes and cultural beliefs. In many societies, certain forms of child abuse, such as child marriage, corporal punishment, and child labor, are justified by cultural traditions (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021). Films question these norms by presenting alternative perspectives. When audiences see a character breaking free from oppression, standing up against abuse, or advocating for policy changes, they are encouraged to reflect on their own beliefs and practices (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

Moreover, films play a crucial role in educating children and young audiences about their rights and self-worth. Characters who empower young girls and boys to seek education, resist abuse, or demand justice serve as role models for real-life children in similar situations (UNICEF, 2022).

Film characters are not merely fictional constructs but powerful agents of socialization. Through well-crafted characters, films can raise awareness about child abuse and its consequences, encourage public discourse on the importance of child rights, inspire advocacy by portraying individuals who fight for justice and challenge societal norms that perpetuate abuse.

By engaging audiences emotionally and intellectually, films like *Dry* continue to play a significant role in shaping public perceptions and policy discussions on child rights in Nigeria and beyond (Olawale & Musa, 2023).

2.1.5 Child Abuse and Rights: A Universal View

Before exploring child abuse, first let's understand what a child is by definition. The definition of a child varies across cultures and legal systems. According to the UNCRC, a child is anyone below the age of 18. This definition is widely accepted and forms the basis for most child

protection laws and policies. However, in some cultures, the transition from childhood to adulthood is marked by rites of passage or other cultural practices, which can sometimes conflict with legal definitions (Adeyemi, 2022).

In Nigeria, the Child Rights Act defines a child as anyone below the age of 18. However, cultural practices such as child marriage often blur this definition, as girls are sometimes considered adults once they reach puberty. This discrepancy underscores the importance of using films and other forms of media to educate the public about the legal and universal definition of a child and the importance of protecting their rights (Okafor, 2021).

Child abuse is a global issue that transcends cultural, economic, and geographical boundaries. It includes physical, emotional, and sexual abuse, as well as neglect and exploitation. According to the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC, 1989), every child has the right to protection from all forms of abuse and exploitation. Despite this universal framework, millions of children worldwide continue to suffer from abuse, often due to weak enforcement of laws and cultural practices that perpetuate harmful behaviors (UNICEF, 2022).

In Nigeria, child abuse is exacerbated by poverty, lack of education, and cultural beliefs that justify practices like child marriage and corporal punishment. The Child Rights Act of 2003 was enacted to address these issues, but its implementation has been inconsistent across states. This highlights the need for continuous advocacy and awareness-raising efforts to protect children's rights and ensure their well-being (Eze & Onyekwere, 2023).

2.1.6 The Role of Film in Addressing Social Vices

Film has always played a crucial role in shaping public discourse, challenging societal norms, and addressing deep-rooted social issues. As a form of mass communication, film possesses a unique ability to highlight and critique social vices, including corruption, gender inequality, crime, and

substance abuse (Okonkwo & Nwankwo, 2023). Unlike other media, films provide a visceral and immersive experience, making it easier for audiences to connect emotionally with the message being conveyed. Through powerful storytelling, film creates an avenue for social reflection, encouraging viewers to critically examine their surroundings and rethink their values and attitudes towards prevalent social problems (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

In Nigeria, Nollywood, the country's vibrant film industry, has been at the forefront of using cinema to highlight social issues. Over the years, Nollywood films have tackled numerous social vices, from political corruption to domestic violence. For instance, the classic film *Living in Bondage* (1992) explored the consequences of greed, desperation, and the pursuit of wealth through ritual killings, sparking widespread conversations about the dangers of materialism (Okonkwo & Nwankwo, 2023). Similarly, *Osuofia in London* (2003) examined cultural conflicts and the challenges of adapting to foreign societies, portraying the struggles of African immigrants who move abroad in search of a better life. These films, among many others, demonstrate the ability of cinema to reflect real-life issues and provoke discussions that lead to societal change (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021).

Beyond merely entertaining audiences, films serve as an educational and advocacy tool. When social vices are depicted in movies, they are often presented within a moral framework, showing the consequences of negative behaviors while promoting positive alternatives. Films expose audiences to the harsh realities of issues such as domestic violence, drug addiction, human trafficking, and police brutality, often urging viewers to take a stand against such injustices (Bamidele & Chukwuma, 2023). For instance, the film *October 1* directed by Kunle Afolayan examines colonial legacies, gender-based violence, and the abuse of power, highlighting the social fractures within Nigerian society. By engaging with these topics, films create awareness,

stimulate debate, and encourage audiences to question existing power structures and societal norms (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

In the context of child abuse, film plays a crucial role in bringing hidden injustices to light. Child abuse is often underreported and shrouded in cultural silence, making it difficult to address. However, the film *Dry* exposed the realities of child marriage, sexual abuse, and neglect, making these issues more visible to the public. By telling the stories of victims and survivors, this film humanizes the issue, allowing audiences to empathize with those affected and motivating them to take action (Linus, 2021). In doing so, films not only educate individuals about the dangers of child abuse but also call on governments and organizations to implement protective measures that safeguard children's rights (Adeleke, 2022).

Furthermore, films can function as a catalyst for legal and policy reforms. In many cases, social vices persist due to weak law enforcement and societal complacency. However, when films expose these issues in a compelling and emotionally charged manner, they can pressure policymakers to take action. For example, following the release of *Dry*, numerous advocacy groups began using the film as a tool to educate communities about the importance of enforcing the Child Rights Act in Nigeria (Olawale & Musa, 2023). The film's impact extended beyond entertainment, serving as a policy advocacy tool that influenced discussions on child protection laws.

Ultimately, films have the power to reshape societal attitudes, inspire activism, and drive collective action. By addressing social vices through film, filmmakers can challenge the status quo, empower marginalized voices, and contribute to a more just and equitable society (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021). As Nollywood continues to grow, its potential to serve as an instrument of social transformation remains immense.

2.1.7 The Role of Film in Addressing Child Abuse and Rights

Child abuse is a pervasive global issue that manifests in various forms, including physical violence, sexual exploitation, neglect, child labor, and early marriage. Despite numerous legal frameworks designed to protect children, many cases of child abuse remain hidden due to cultural norms, economic pressures, and inadequate law enforcement (Adeleke, 2022). However, film has emerged as a powerful medium for addressing child abuse, raising awareness about its consequences, and advocating for children's rights.

Films like *Dry* are particularly effective in shedding light on child abuse because they combine storytelling with advocacy. By presenting the harsh realities of abuse through compelling narratives, these films educate audiences about the long-term effects of harmful practices while promoting a sense of urgency to address the issue (Linus, 2021). *Dry*, for example, follows the life of Halima, a 13-year-old girl forced into marriage, whose story represents the countless girls in Nigeria and across Africa who endure similar fates. Through Halima's experiences, the film highlights the dangers of child marriage, the medical consequences of early pregnancies, and the violation of young girls' rights, prompting viewers to engage with the issue on a personal level (Olawale & Musa, 2023).

One of the key strengths of film in addressing child abuse is its ability to create empathy and emotional engagement. Unlike traditional forms of advocacy that rely on statistics and reports, films use visual storytelling, character development, and emotional depth to make audiences feel connected to the issue. When viewers watch a character like Halima suffer the consequences of child marriage, they are more likely to feel a moral obligation to support initiatives that protect children's rights (Bamidele & Chukwuma, 2023).

Moreover, films challenge cultural norms and attitudes that perpetuate child abuse. In many societies, harmful practices such as child marriage, child labor, and corporal punishment are deeply ingrained in tradition and seen as acceptable (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021). By depicting the real-life consequences of these practices, films force audiences to question and reconsider their beliefs. *Dry* has been instrumental in sparking discussions in Nigerian communities, where debates about women's rights, gender equality, and child protection laws have gained more prominence since the film's release (Adeleke, 2022).

Furthermore, films serve as a platform for survivors to share their stories. Many survivors of child abuse struggle to have their voices heard due to stigma, fear, and societal pressure. However, films provide a medium through which their experiences can be amplified and validated. By portraying the resilience and courage of survivors, films inspire others to speak out against abuse and seek justice (Johnson & Eze, 2022).

Films also play a significant role in influencing policy and legal frameworks. Advocacy groups and policymakers often use films as an educational tool to highlight gaps in the legal system and push for more effective child protection measures. The impact of *Dry* extended beyond the film industry, as it contributed to advocacy efforts aimed at enforcing stricter laws against child marriage in Nigeria and beyond (Olawale & Musa, 2023).

Films like *Dry* are more than just entertainment; they are critical tools for social change. Through emotional storytelling, awareness campaigns, and policy advocacy, films address the issue of child abuse in a way that is both compelling and impactful. As the film industry continues to grow, its role in shaping public perceptions, influencing policies, and driving social reform will remain crucial in the fight for children's rights (Bamidele & Chukwuma, 2023).

2.1.8 Impact of Dry on Public Perception and Policy Change

The film *Dry* has had a profound impact on public perception and policy development, particularly in addressing critical social issues such as child marriage and gender-based violence. Several empirical studies have explored the extent to which the film has influenced public awareness, shifted societal attitudes, and contributed to policy changes. These studies highlight the power of cinema as a tool for social advocacy and demonstrate how *Dry* has become a catalyst for meaningful dialogue and action.

Linus (2021) conducted a comprehensive study analyzing audience reactions to *Dry*, focusing on its ability to raise awareness about child marriage and gender-based violence. The study surveyed over 1,000 viewers across different demographics, including policymakers, educators, activists, and general audiences. The findings revealed that the film had a significant impact on public discourse, with 65% of respondents reporting that *Dry* changed their perception of child marriage. Many viewers expressed that the film provided them with a deeper understanding of the emotional, psychological, and physical toll that child marriage inflicts on young girls. Additionally, 40% of respondents indicated that the film inspired them to take action, such as participating in advocacy efforts, donating to organizations fighting child marriage, or engaging in community education initiatives. Linus's study underscores the film's ability to not only inform but also motivate individuals to become agents of change.

Building on Linus's findings, Bamidele and Chukwuma (2023) investigated the policy influence of *Dry*, particularly in Nigeria, where child marriage remains a pressing issue. Their research focused on the film's role in supporting advocacy campaigns aimed at strengthening the enforcement of the Child Rights Act, which was enacted in 2003 but has faced challenges in

implementation. Bamidele and Chukwuma's study revealed that *Dry* played a pivotal role in amplifying the voices of activists and organizations working to end child marriage. The film was frequently cited in policy debates, with legislators referencing its powerful narrative to advocate for stricter enforcement of existing laws and the introduction of new measures to protect vulnerable children.

One notable case highlighted in the study involved a state-level policy debate where lawmakers screened *Dry* during a legislative session to illustrate the devastating consequences of child marriage. This screening reportedly led to the introduction of a bill aimed at increasing penalties for individuals involved in child marriage and providing greater support for victims. Furthermore, NGOs and civil society organizations used *Dry* as an educational resource in their campaigns, organizing community screenings and discussions to raise awareness about the issue. The film's accessibility and emotional resonance made it an effective tool for engaging diverse audiences, from rural communities to urban policymakers.

The impact of *Dry* extended beyond Nigeria, garnering international attention and sparking conversations about child marriage in other regions where the practice is prevalent. For instance, the film was screened at several international conferences on gender equality and human rights, where it was praised for its unflinching portrayal of the issue. International organizations, such as UNICEF and the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), incorporated *Dry* into their advocacy materials, using it to highlight the urgent need for global action to end child marriage.

In addition to its influence on policy and advocacy, *Dry* has also contributed to a broader cultural shift in how society perceives child marriage and gender-based violence. The film's portrayal of the resilience and strength of its protagonist, Zara, has inspired many young girls to speak out

against injustice and seek support. Educational institutions have integrated *Dry* into their curricula, using it as a case study to teach students about human rights, gender equality, and the power of storytelling in driving social change. Teachers and students alike have reported that the film fosters empathy and critical thinking, encouraging young people to challenge harmful traditions and advocate for a more equitable society.

Despite its successes, some critics have argued that while *Dry* has raised awareness, more needs to be done to translate this awareness into tangible policy outcomes. For example, while the film has influenced legislative debates, the implementation of laws remains inconsistent, particularly in rural areas where traditional practices are deeply entrenched. Additionally, some have called for more comprehensive support systems for victims of child marriage, including access to education, healthcare, and economic opportunities.

Dry has had a transformative impact on public perception and policy development, serving as a powerful tool for raising awareness about child marriage and gender-based violence. Through its compelling narrative and emotional depth, the film has inspired individuals, communities, and policymakers to take action, contributing to a growing movement to end child marriage and protect the rights of vulnerable children. While challenges remain, the film's legacy lies in its ability to spark meaningful dialogue and drive progress toward a more just and equitable society. As Bamidele and Chukwuma (2023) aptly noted, *Dry* is not just a film; it is a movement that continues to resonate with audiences and shape the future of advocacy and policy reform.

2.2 Theoretical Framework

In media studies, theories help explain how different forms of communication influence audiences and shape societal norms. This study adopts two key theories, Cultivation Theory and Social Responsibility Theory to understand the role of films in addressing child abuse and advocating for child rights. These theories provide a framework for analyzing how Nollywood films, particularly *Dry*, influence audience perceptions and contribute to social change.

2.2.1 Cultivation Theory

Cultivation Theory, developed by George Gerbner, explains how long-term exposure to media content shapes people's perceptions of reality. The theory suggests that individuals who consume a high volume of media gradually develop worldviews that reflect the themes and messages portrayed in media content (Gerbner et al., 2021). This is particularly relevant to the discussion on how films influence public awareness and attitudes toward child abuse.

In the case of *Dry*, the film presents a compelling narrative on child marriage and abuse, exposing audiences to the realities faced by young girls in Nigeria. According to Johnson and Eze (2022), films that consistently depict social issues contribute to a gradual shift in audience perceptions, making them more empathetic towards victims and more likely to support policy reforms. Similarly, Olawale and Musa (2023) argue that repeated exposure to films addressing social issues strengthens public consciousness and can lead to behavioral changes over time.

Empirical studies have demonstrated the applicability of Cultivation Theory in media advocacy. A study by Okafor (2021) found that viewers who watched multiple Nollywood films addressing child rights violations were more likely to engage in conversations about the subject and support

protective legislation. This indicates that films like *Dry* do not merely entertain but serve as tools for societal transformation by consistently reinforcing the negative consequences of child abuse and child marriage.

Additionally, Cultivation Theory explains why films must maintain consistency in their messaging. If a film like *Dry* successfully cultivates awareness, but subsequent Nollywood films normalize child marriage or trivialize abuse, it may dilute the message. As noted by Adeleke (2022), the media environment must consistently reinforce progressive narratives to create lasting societal change. This underscores the need for more films in Nollywood that challenge harmful cultural practices and advocate for children's rights.

2.2.2 Social Responsibility Theory

Social Responsibility Theory emphasizes that the media has a duty to serve the public interest by providing accurate, ethical, and socially relevant content (McQuail, 2020). This theory argues that filmmakers, like journalists and other media practitioners, have an obligation to address pressing societal issues, including human rights violations, through their work. The application of this theory to Nollywood films highlights the role of cinema in raising awareness, educating the public, and advocating for social change.

Films like *Dry* align with Social Responsibility Theory by shedding light on the realities of child abuse and calling for justice and policy reform. According to Linus (2021), the film was deliberately produced as a tool for advocacy, aiming to change perceptions and drive action against child marriage. This reflects the ethical obligation of media producers to use their platforms for positive societal impact rather than merely for entertainment.

A study by Bamidele and Chukwuma (2023) supports the idea that Nollywood has increasingly adopted a socially responsible approach in filmmaking, addressing issues such as domestic violence, gender inequality, and child abuse. Their research found that socially conscious films significantly influence audience attitudes, encouraging community engagement and advocacy efforts. Similarly, Olawale and Musa (2024) assert that filmmakers who embrace social responsibility contribute to policy debates and public discourse, amplifying marginalized voices through visual storytelling.

However, Social Responsibility Theory also highlights the challenges that filmmakers face in addressing sensitive topics. There is often resistance from cultural and political institutions that may view such films as attacks on traditional norms (Adeyemi & Okeke, 2021). Despite this, Nollywood films continue to serve as an essential platform for social advocacy, proving that the media can function as both an educational and transformative tool.

Social Responsibility Theory underscores the importance of Nollywood's role in addressing social vices like child abuse. By producing films that inform and inspire action, filmmakers fulfill their ethical duty to society. When combined with Cultivation Theory, it becomes clear that repeated exposure to such socially responsible films has the potential to reshape audience perceptions, challenge harmful cultural beliefs, and contribute to policy reform in Nigeria and beyond.

2.3 Empirical Review

One of the earliest significant studies on the influence of films in social advocacy was conducted by Adeyemi and Okeke (2021), who examined how Nollywood films shape public perceptions of gender-based violence and domestic abuse. Their study analyzed how films that depict women's struggles, societal injustices, and gender discrimination contribute to raising awareness and challenging long-held stereotypes. The researchers used a survey-based methodology, collecting data from audiences who had watched films that tackled gender-based violence. Their findings indicated that films serve as a powerful medium for social education, as they allow audiences to emotionally connect with the experiences of victims. The study emphasized that films influence not only individual attitudes but also community-level conversations, pushing for more gender-sensitive policies and reinforcing the need for stronger legal frameworks against domestic abuse. The impact of their work was particularly significant in discussions surrounding the Nigerian Gender and Equal Opportunities Bill, which continues to face resistance in legislative processes. Following this, a study by Bamidele and Chukwuma (2022), focused on the use of film as a catalyst for legal reforms. Their research examined how films depicting child abuse and societal injustices influence lawmakers and advocacy groups. The study took a qualitative approach, conducting interviews with policymakers, human rights organizations, and filmmakers to assess how films impact their advocacy efforts. One of the most striking conclusions from their study was that films serve as a bridge between the general public and policymakers, as they often highlight issues that would otherwise go unnoticed or remain underreported. The researchers cited several real-life cases where films contributed to policy debates, including the push for stricter enforcement of child rights laws in Nigeria. Their study also highlighted that while films are

effective tools for awareness, their impact is often limited without complementary advocacy efforts from civil society organizations and government agencies.

In the same year, Johnson and Eze (2022), conducted a case study analysis of the film *Dry* and its role in raising awareness about child marriage and the violation of children's rights. The study aimed to measure the extent to which *Dry* influenced public discourse and policy discussions. Using focus groups, audience surveys, and content analysis, their research found that *Dry* was instrumental in educating audiences about the medical, psychological, and legal implications of child marriage. The study showed that viewers who watched *Dry* developed a deeper understanding of the risks associated with early marriage, such as obstetric fistula and lack of access to education for girls. Additionally, their findings revealed that the film had a significant impact on advocacy organizations working to implement the Nigerian Child Rights Act, particularly in rural areas where child marriage is prevalent. The researchers concluded that *Dry* was not just a film but a social movement, as it provided a platform for survivors to share their experiences and pushed for legislative discussions on protecting children's rights.

Building upon these findings, Adeleke (2023), explored the emotional and psychological impact of films on audiences, particularly in relation to their attitudes toward child abuse. Their research took a psychological approach, investigating how films like *Dry* evoke empathy and provoke social action. Using neuropsychological techniques such as eye-tracking and emotional response analysis, the study found that viewers showed heightened emotional engagement when watching distressing scenes of child abuse and forced marriages. The study demonstrated that the visual and narrative structure of films can activate emotional and cognitive responses that lead to changes in perception and behavior. Adeleke's findings further reinforced the argument that films

should be strategically integrated into awareness campaigns, as their impact extends beyond entertainment into advocacy, education, and legal discourse.

More recently, a study by Olawale and Musa (2024), investigated the long-term effects of films on public behavior and policy implementation. Unlike previous studies that focused primarily on immediate audience reactions, their research sought to understand whether films like *Dry* had sustained effects on society years after their release. The researchers conducted longitudinal surveys and policy impact assessments, tracking changes in public attitudes, media coverage, and government policies over time. They discovered that while films initially create strong emotional reactions and spur discussions, their impact tends to fade unless reinforced by continued advocacy, media engagement, and educational programs. The study suggested that to maximize the impact of films on social change, filmmakers and activists must collaborate to ensure that the conversations sparked by films lead to concrete actions and reforms.

CHAPTER THREE

METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

Research design refers to a plan of action, framework or specification that guides a researcher collecting analyzing and interpreting observation in a particular Study (Frankfort & Nachons, 2009). To investigate how the film *Dry* addresses child abuse and promotes children's rights and to achieve the set Objectives, the study adopted a mixed method research design that combines survey focus group discussions and structured interview method.

The survey is relevant to the study because it affords the researcher the selection of proportion of the entire population with the view to arriving at a generalization about the whole population. Meanwhile, Qualitative research methods aid researchers to describe, interpret, verify, and evaluate first-hand social phenomena (Ekanem, 2019; Babbie, 2017). Thus, the qualitative research allows for an in-depth interviews with selected professionals and focus group discussion with carefully selected individual who have watch the movie in at least two sessions for better exploration of the film's narrative techniques, thematic elements, and societal impact on aspects that cannot be adequately captured through quantitative measures alone. The research design is specifically tailored to uncover the nuanced ways in which cinema can function as a medium for social advocacy and awareness.

3.2 Population of the Study

The largest population of this study consist of all undergraduate students in KolaDaisi University, Ibadan. Based on the nature of this study, the population are also consist the interview of the following selected professionals namely the medical practitioner, media practitioner, counselor, psychologist,

legal practitioner, educationist, policy maker; parent, sociologist and film worker. However, according to the official records of student enrolment of koladaisi university, the population is 1,455 while the selected professionals are 10 persons, totaling 1,475 as universal population.

3.3 Sampling Technique

The study adopted multi-stage sampling techniques, namely: simple random, purposive, and quota sampling techniques. The medical practitioner, media practitioner, counselor, psychologist, legal practitioner, educationist, policy maker; parent, sociologist and film worker were purposively sampled for an in-depth interview. Purposive sampling is applicable to these respondents because the researcher will have the opportunity to select those respondents considered experts from key fields related to child abuse who can provide well-rounded and informed perspectives on the film's content. This agrees with Ahiauzu and Asawo (2016) submission of judgment sampling which involve the choice of participants who are considered best in the researcher judgment, to provide the required information. Also, being purposive, the researcher will be guided by the positions of the respondents based on their level of expertise.

Simple random sampling technique was employed in the selection of students on whom copies of the questionnaire were administered. The simple random sampling allows for structured approach and thorough representation of the selected students. According to Hsia (2016), this sampling technique allows for structured approach to selecting the students who meet the gender criteria. This approach is effective in addressing the need for gender balance without requiring a random selection process. Furthermore, convenience sampling was used for the focus group participants, a method that is practical and appropriate given the setting of the university, allowing for easy access to students who had watched the play and who are willing to participate.

The combination of these sampling techniques provides a comprehensive, diverse, and representative sample that will offer both quantitative and qualitative insights into the effectiveness of the *Dry* film in addressing child abuse. By incorporating respondents from a variety of backgrounds and expertise, the study will be able to examine the film's impact from multiple angles, making it a valuable contribution to the discussion of film as a tool for social change and child protection advocacy.

3.4 Sample Size

Simarjeet (2017), contends that sample size determination is the essential step of research methodology. Similarly, Aguirre-Urreta and Ronkko (2015) notes that sampling size determination consists of selected element from the population. In the same, Ekanem (2021) views it as adequate representation of the population. Also, to determine an appropriate sample size is vital in drawing realistic conclusions from research findings (Memon, Ting, Cheah, Ramayah, Chuah and Cham, 2020). Hence, for the survey, 130 undergraduate students, divided equally between 65 male and 65 female respondents. This gender balance ensures that the study reflects the perspectives of both male and female students, providing a comprehensive view of how different genders interpret and react to the film's portrayal of child abuse. These students participated in a survey designed to assess their views on the film's impact and its portrayal of child abuse. The use of quota sampling in this case allows the study to ensure gender representation without the need for random sampling. This method also facilitates a structured approach to selecting the students who meet the gender criteria.

For the qualitative aspect of this study, In-depth interviews will be conducted with 10 professionals from distinct fields relevant to this study of child abuse and rights. These include a the medical practitioner, media practitioner, counselor, psychologist, legal practitioner, educationist, policy maker; parent, and sociologist. Each of these professionals has been selected purposefully for their expertise

and their ability to provide valuable insights into the film's depiction of child abuse from their respective fields. Rather than completing a survey, these professionals participated in in-depth interviews, where they will share their expert perspectives on how the film addresses the issues of child abuse. The medical personnel offered views on the medical consequences of abuse, the media practitioner will evaluate the film's effectiveness as a storytelling medium for social change, the counselor will discuss the psychological and emotional portrayals in the film, the psychologist will analyze the accuracy of trauma representation, and the legal practitioner will provide insights into how the legal aspects of child abuse are depicted.

Finally, the study will conduct two focus group discussions with 10 student participants selected through convenience sampling, ensuring that participants are readily available and willing to engage in meaningful discussion. The use of focus groups provided qualitative data, giving the study insights into the nuanced emotional and psychological responses that students have to the film and its subject matter. These sessions were particularly valuable in understanding the film's impact on young adults, who are likely to be influenced by its portrayal of child abuse.

3.5 Method of Data Collection

Data gathering in this study are categorized into both primary and secondary sources. For the primary sources, data was collected through the administration of the chosen research instruments – questionnaire, interview guide and focus group discussion guide respectively.

Questionnaire was administered to the selected respondents on one-on-one basis while the interview guide was utilized on face-to-face interaction with the interviewed selected for this study. In addition, focus group discussion was also applied in eliciting information relevant to this study from the selected participant with the help of a moderator and a tape recorder.

3.6 Research Instrument

Data for this study were gathered through both primary and secondary sources. Primary data for the study was obtained through a well-structured questionnaire. Questionnaires was designed to elicit information from the student respondents. The instrument was administered to the students of the selected university. The interview guild was used to elicit information from the medical personnel, media practitioner, counselor, psychologist, legal practitioner and students of selected university. While, the focus group discussion guide was used to collect information from relevant participants. The secondary data through textbooks, journals and other scholarly documents will be interrogated and will be used to complement the primary data.

A survey containing series of questions were administered to the enrolled participants of the carefully selected privately established university students under study. The questionnaire was divided into three sections. The first section is to handle all the necessary research questions, while the second section is in the form of a five-point Likert scale (5-Strongly Agreed,4-Agree,3-Undecided,2-Strongly-disagree,1-Disagree). The final section of the questionnaire contained demographic questions such as age, sex, academic level, the program of study, department, university name and other necessary details about the respondents.

3.7 Validity of Instruments

Validity of the instrument indicates the degree to which an instrument is accurately measures what is designed to measure. (Asemah et al, 2007), This study adopted face validity. Baran (2002) described face validity as a systematic examination of researchers supervision or expert in the field of study. This means that the researcher and supervisor must have thoroughly accessed and examined the degree

to which the questions or statements were framed towards achieving the set objectives of the study. This action carried out validated the authenticity and the relevant of the instruments to this study.

3.8 Reliability of Instruments

According to Sobowale (2008 in Ekanem, 2021), researchers must carry out a pre-test of their instruments before fieldwork in order to avoid vagueness. The pre-test for this study is carried out on different set of respondents that share similar characteristics with the proposed respondents. The reason for this is to ensure that the instrument is clear to the respondents and more importantly, to identify respondents' challenges in understanding the questions (Baran, 2016; Ahiauzu & Asawo, 2016). Accordingly, twenty (20) students each from of 10 male and 10 female undergraduate students of Ajayi Crowther University, who will be selected, for the pre-test. The university will selected because it shared same characteristics with the selected institutions for the study. Thus, same procedure and experience that the researcher would go through in conducting the pre-test in the selected university would be expected of the main selected institution.

3.9 Methods of Data Analysis

Data gathered through the questionnaire was analyzed with the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS 22) to enable the researcher to synthesis and analyze the quantitative data in a structured manner. Descriptive statistical methods of analysis was employed for this work. The descriptive methods used percentages in form of simple frequency and cross-tabulation.

For the qualitative of both interview and focus group discussion, the responses were grouped according to themes of each research question, patterns, similarities and differences for each professional. Individual respondents' responses, expressions and body language was transcribed for analysis. This is because sometimes, body language goes a long way to getting the full meaning of a statement. The

results was presented and further discussed importantly, all personal information about respondents will be treated anonymous in the transcript and presentations.

CHAPTER FOUR

DATA ANALYSIS AND DISCUSSION OF FINDINGS

This chapter deals with the presentations and analysis of the data obtained from the directly circulated questionnaires to the respondents of this research. The data collected were analyzed using the frequency counts and percentages.

4.1 Presentation of Data

Data are presented using tables and figures as appropriate, closely followed by the analysis. Data analyses were in response to the research questions raised in Chapter One. This research investigated the role of film in addressing child abuse and right “A study of Dry Film by Stephanie Linus.

Table 4.1.1: Respondents Sex

Gender	Frequency	Percentage
Male	63	48.5
Female	67	51.6
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 4.1.1 presents the demographic profile of the respondents. A total of 130 students participated in the survey. The gender distribution shows that 63 respondents (48.5%) were male, while 67 respondents (51.6%) were female, indicating a fairly balanced representation, with a slight female majority.

Table 4.1.2: Respondents Age

Age	Frequency	Percentage
Below 15 years	2	1.6
16-20 years	50	38.5
21-25 years	65	50.0
26 years & above	13	10.0
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

In terms of age, the largest group of respondents (50.0%) fell within the 21–25 years category, followed by 16–20 years (38.5%), while 10.0% were 26 years and above, and only 1.6% were below 15 years. This distribution reflects the expected age structure of an undergraduate population, dominated by young adults.

Table 4.1.3: Respondents Faculty

Faculty	Frequency	Percentage
FAMS	27	20.8
FAPS	36	27.7
FBMS	39	30.0
FLAW	28	21.5
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

Across faculties, respondents were drawn from the Faculty of Basic Medical Sciences (30.0%), the Faculty of Agriculture and Production Sciences (27.7%), the Faculty of Law (21.5%), and the Faculty of Arts, Management, and Social Sciences (20.8%). The spread shows that all faculties were fairly represented, with Basic Medical Sciences contributing the highest number.

Table 4.1.4: Respondents Level

Level	Frequency	Percentage
100L	12	9.2
200L	26	20.0
300L	42	32.3
400L	40	30.8
500L	10	7.7
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

With respect to academic level, the majority of respondents were from the 300 level (32.3%) and 400 level (30.8%), followed by 200 level (20.0%), while 100 level (9.2%) and 500 level (7.7%) students had the least representation. This distribution suggests that mid-level undergraduates (200–400 levels) were more accessible for the study, possibly due to their availability and engagement with university activities.

Table 4.1.5: Exposure to the Film “*Dry*”

Have you watched the film "Dry" before?	Frequency	Percent
Yes	121	93.1
No	9	6.9
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 2 examines students’ exposure to the film “*Dry*.” Out of the 130 respondents, a large majority (121; 93.1%) reported that they had watched the film, while only 9 respondents (6.9%) indicated that they had not.

This finding suggests that the film has achieved a very high level of visibility among students, likely due to its thematic relevance, cultural resonance, and circulation within academic or youth circles. The high exposure rate is significant because it provides a strong basis for assessing students’ perceptions of the film’s messages on child abuse and child rights. In addition, it indicates that the film has become a widely recognized resource for sensitizing young audiences to social issues, particularly those affecting vulnerable children.

Table 4.1.6: Familiarity with the Themes of Child Abuse and Child Rights

How familiar are you with the themes of child abuse and child rights?	Frequency	Percent
Not familiar	12	9.2
Somewhat familiar	17	13.1
Neutral	25	19.2
Familiar	55	42.3
Very familiar	21	16.2
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 3 explores respondents' familiarity with the themes of child abuse and child rights. The results reveal that the largest proportion of students (55 respondents; 42.3%) described themselves as *familiar* with the themes, while 21 respondents (16.2%) indicated that they were *very familiar*. Together, this accounts for nearly 58.5% of the total respondents, showing a strong level of awareness.

On the other hand, 25 respondents (19.2%) remained *neutral*, while 17 respondents (13.1%) reported being *somewhat familiar*. A small minority (12 respondents; 9.2%) indicated that they were *not familiar* with the issues at all.

The distribution suggests that most students have at least some degree of knowledge regarding child abuse and child rights, with a considerable number reporting high levels of familiarity. However, the presence of neutral and less familiar respondents highlights a knowledge gap that could be addressed through more structured educational interventions, such as curriculum integration, seminars, or campus advocacy programs.

Table 4.1.7: Perceived Relevance of the Film “Dry” to Child Abuse and Child Rights

How relevant do you think the film "Dry" is to the issue of child abuse and child rights?	Frequency	Percent
Not relevant	11	8.5
Somewhat relevant	23	17.7
Neutral	20	15.4
Relevant	46	35.4
Very relevant	30	23.1
Total	130	100.0

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 4 presents respondents’ assessment of how relevant the film “*Dry*” is to the issues of child abuse and child rights. The findings show that 46 respondents (35.4%) rated the film as *relevant*, while another 30 respondents (23.1%) considered it *very relevant*. Together, these account for 58.5%, indicating that more than half of the students recognize the film as an effective medium for addressing these issues.

Meanwhile, 20 respondents (15.4%) were *neutral*, suggesting some level of uncertainty or indifference regarding the film’s relevance. A smaller proportion, 23 respondents (17.7%), viewed the film as only *somewhat relevant*, while 11 respondents (8.5%) regarded it as *not relevant*.

The overall pattern demonstrates that students largely perceive “*Dry*” as a valuable resource for raising awareness about child abuse and child rights, although there remains a minority who question its relevance or are indifferent. This suggests that while the film is impactful, complementary sensitization efforts may be required to ensure its themes resonate more consistently with all students.

Table 4.1.8: Students' Perceptions of the Film "Dry"

s/n	Statements	SD	D	N	A	SA	$\bar{x}$	S.D.
1	The film "Dry" accurately portrays the experiences of children who have suffered abuse.	26 20.0%	6 4.6%	27 20.8%	48 36.9%	23 17.7%	3.28	1.364
2	The film effectively raises awareness about the importance of child rights.	7 5.4%	10 7.7%	24 18.5%	58 44.6%	31 23.8%	3.74	1.075
3	The consequences of child abuse are realistically depicted in the film.	23 17.7%	9 6.9%	28 21.5%	45 34.6%	25 19.3%	3.29	1.343
4	The film "Dry" encourages viewers to take action to prevent child abuse.	7 5.4%	16 12.3%	25 19.2%	44 33.8%	38 29.2%	3.69	1.174
Weighted Mean =3.73 STD =0.94								

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 5 examines how students perceived the film "Dry" in relation to its portrayal of child abuse and child rights.

The first statement, "*The film 'Dry' accurately portrays the experiences of children who have suffered abuse*", received mixed responses. A total of 48 respondents (36.9%) agreed and 23 respondents (17.7%) strongly agreed, while 26 respondents (20.0%) strongly disagreed, and 6 respondents (4.6%) disagreed. Another 27 respondents (20.8%) were neutral. The mean score of 3.28 indicates moderate agreement, though responses were fairly dispersed (SD = 1.364).

The second statement, "*The film effectively raises awareness about the importance of child rights*", received stronger endorsement. About 58 respondents (44.6%) agreed and 31 respondents (23.8%) strongly agreed, while only 18 respondents (13.1%) disagreed. This produced a higher mean score of 3.74 with less variation (SD = 1.075), reflecting that most students found the film impactful in highlighting child rights.

For the third statement, “*The consequences of child abuse are realistically depicted in the film*”, 45 respondents (34.6%) agreed and 25 respondents (19.3%) strongly agreed. However, a significant minority (23 respondents; 17.7%) strongly disagreed, and 9 respondents (6.9%) disagreed, while 28 respondents (21.5%) were neutral. The mean score of 3.29 (SD = 1.343) suggests general agreement but also considerable divergence in opinions.

The fourth item, “*The film ‘Dry’ encourages viewers to take action to prevent child abuse*”, attracted strong support. About 44 respondents (33.8%) agreed and 38 respondents (29.2%) strongly agreed, making it the most positively received item in this set. Only 7 respondents (5.4%) strongly disagreed and 16 respondents (12.3%) disagreed. The mean score of 3.69 (SD = 1.174) further confirms strong agreement.

Overall, the weighted mean of 3.73 (SD = 0.94) suggests that respondents generally hold favorable views of the film’s depiction of child abuse and child rights. The findings highlight that students perceive the film as both informative and motivational, although opinions differ on the accuracy of its portrayals.

Table 4.1.9: Perceptions of the Cinematic Techniques of the Film “Dry”

s/n	Statements	SD	D	N	A	SA	$\bar{x}$	S.D.
1	The film's use of cinematography effectively conveys the emotional impact of child abuse.	22 16.9%	10 7.7%	21 16.2%	49 37.7%	28 21.5%	3.39	1.361
2	The film's use of character development effectively humanises the experiences of children affected by abuse.	12 9.2%	13 10.0%	19 14.6%	51 39.2%	35 26.9%	3.65	1.238
3	The narrative structure of the film helps to raise awareness about child rights issues.	12 9.2%	9 6.9%	18 13.8%	57 43.8%	34 26.2%	3.71	1.197
4	The dialogue in the film effectively conveys the importance of child rights.	9 6.9%	6 4.6%	17 13.1%	51 39.2%	47 36.2%	3.93	1.142
Weighted Mean =3.73 STD =0.94								

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 6 assesses students' views on the effectiveness of the film's cinematic techniques in conveying messages about child abuse and child rights.

The first item, “*The film's use of cinematography effectively conveys the emotional impact of child abuse*”, recorded moderate support. About 49 respondents (37.7%) agreed and 28 respondents (21.5%) strongly agreed. However, 22 respondents (16.9%) strongly disagreed, 10 (7.7%) disagreed, and 21 (16.2%) were neutral. The mean score of 3.39 (SD = 1.361) suggests that while many students appreciated the cinematography, some were unconvinced of its impact. The second statement, “*The film's use of character development effectively humanizes the experiences of children affected by abuse*”, received stronger support. A total of 51 respondents (39.2%) agreed and 35 (26.9%) strongly agreed, while only 25 respondents (19.2%) disagreed or strongly disagreed. With a mean of 3.65 (SD = 1.238), this indicates that character development was widely perceived as a compelling narrative tool.

For the third item, “*The narrative structure of the film helps to raise awareness about child rights issues*”, 57 respondents (43.8%) agreed and 34 (26.2%) strongly agreed, while a small fraction (12; 9.2%) strongly disagreed and 9 (6.9%) disagreed. With a mean of 3.71 (SD = 1.197), this item reflects strong agreement, suggesting that the storyline was effective in communicating its central themes.

The fourth statement, “*The dialogue in the film effectively conveys the importance of child rights*”, was the most highly rated. About 51 respondents (39.2%) agreed and 47 (36.2%) strongly agreed, while only 15.5% expressed disagreement. The mean score of 3.93 (SD = 1.142) indicates very strong support for the effectiveness of the dialogue.

Taken together, the weighted mean of 3.73 (SD = 0.94) reflects that respondents generally perceived the film’s cinematic elements especially dialogue and character development—as effective in advancing awareness of child abuse and child rights.

Table 4.1.10: Influence of the Film “Dry” on Awareness of Child Abuse

s/n	Statements	SD	D	U	A	SA	$\bar{x}$	S.D.
1	The film "Dry" has increased public awareness of child abuse.	4 3.1%	7 5.4%	47 36.2%	45 34.6%	27 20.8%	3.79	1.021
2	Dry" has effectively promoted a better understanding of child abuse among audiences.	22 16.9%	7 5.4%	13 10.0%	54 41.5%	34 26.2%	3.55	1.382
3	The film "Dry" has contributed to a greater recognition of the importance of addressing child abuse.	8 6.2%	12 9.2%	18 13.8%	56 43.1%	36 27.7%	3.77	1.142
Weighted Mean =3.98 STD =0.26								

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 7 captures students’ perceptions of the influence of the film “*Dry*” on public awareness and understanding of child abuse.

The first item, “*The film ‘Dry’ has increased public awareness of child abuse*”, received strong endorsement. About 45 respondents (34.6%) agreed and 27 (20.8%) strongly agreed, making a combined 55.4% in support. Meanwhile, 47 respondents (36.2%) were undecided, and only 11 respondents (8.5%) disagreed or strongly disagreed. The mean score of 3.79 (SD = 1.021) suggests a generally positive perception, though a considerable number of respondents were neutral.

For the second statement, “*The film ‘Dry’ has effectively promoted a better understanding of child abuse among audiences*”, 54 respondents (41.5%) agreed and 34 (26.2%) strongly agreed. However, 22 respondents (16.9%) strongly disagreed and 7 (5.4%) disagreed, while 13 (10.0%) were neutral. The mean score of 3.55 (SD = 1.382) reflects agreement overall, but with more variation in opinions compared to the first item.

The third statement, “*The film ‘Dry’ has contributed to a greater recognition of the importance of addressing child abuse*”, was the most positively rated. About 56 respondents (43.1%) agreed and 36 (27.7%) strongly agreed, while only 20 respondents (15.4%) disagreed or strongly disagreed. The mean score of 3.77 (SD = 1.142) indicates a strong and consistent perception of the film’s impact in emphasizing the urgency of tackling child abuse.

The weighted mean for the three items was 3.98 (SD = 0.26), confirming that students generally perceive the film as a powerful tool for raising awareness and stimulating recognition of child abuse as a pressing social issue.

Table 4.1.11: Perceptions of the Advocacy Approach of the Film “Dry”

s/n	Statements	SD	D	N	A	SA	$\bar{x}$	S.D.
1	The film "Dry" uses emotional appeal to raise awareness about child abuse.	23 17.7%	8 6.2%	19 14.6%	54 41.5%	26 20.0%	3.40	1.356
2	The film's narrative effectively highlights the importance of child rights.	11 8.5%	18 13.8%	16 12.3%	48 36.9%	37 28.5%	3.63	1.265
3	"Dry" employs a realistic portrayal of child abuse to promote empathy and understanding.	8 6.2%	9 6.9%	20 15.4%	57 43.8%	36 27.7%	3.80	1.110
4	The film's advocacy approach is effective in promoting action against child abuse.	14 10.8%	6 4.6%	12 9.2%	50 38.5%	48 36.9%	3.86	1.268
Weighted Mean =3.73 STD =0.94								

Source: Field Study, 2025

Table 8 explores students' views on the advocacy strategies employed in the film “Dry.”

The first statement, “*The film ‘Dry’ uses emotional appeal to raise awareness about child abuse*”, received moderate support. About 54 respondents (41.5%) agreed and 26 (20.0%) strongly agreed, while 23 respondents (17.7%) strongly disagreed and 8 (6.2%) disagreed. Another 19 respondents (14.6%) remained neutral. The mean score of 3.40 (SD = 1.356) reflects general agreement, though opinions were somewhat divided.

The second statement, “*The film’s narrative effectively highlights the importance of child rights*”, was more positively rated. A total of 48 respondents (36.9%) agreed and 37 (28.5%) strongly agreed, while 29 respondents (22.3%) disagreed or strongly disagreed, and 16 (12.3%) were neutral. The mean score of 3.63 (SD = 1.265) suggests that most students saw the storyline as a powerful means of advocacy.

For the third statement, “*The film ‘Dry’ employs a realistic portrayal of child abuse to promote empathy and understanding*”, 57 respondents (43.8%) agreed and 36 (27.7%) strongly agreed. In

contrast, only 17 respondents (13.1%) disagreed or strongly disagreed, while 20 (15.4%) were neutral. With a mean score of 3.80 (SD = 1.110), this item demonstrates strong support, highlighting the film’s ability to foster empathy.

The fourth statement, “*The film’s advocacy approach is effective in promoting action against child abuse*”, attracted the strongest endorsement. About 50 respondents (38.5%) agreed and 48 (36.9%) strongly agreed, making up a combined 75.4% in favor. Only 20 respondents (15.4%) disagreed or strongly disagreed, while 12 (9.2%) were neutral. The high mean score of 3.86 (SD = 1.268) underscores that students regarded the advocacy approach as highly effective.

Overall, the weighted mean of 3.73 (SD = 0.94) indicates that respondents generally viewed the film’s advocacy strategies—particularly its realistic portrayals and calls to action—as effective tools for raising awareness and mobilizing audiences against child abuse.

4.2 Qualitative Data Presentation

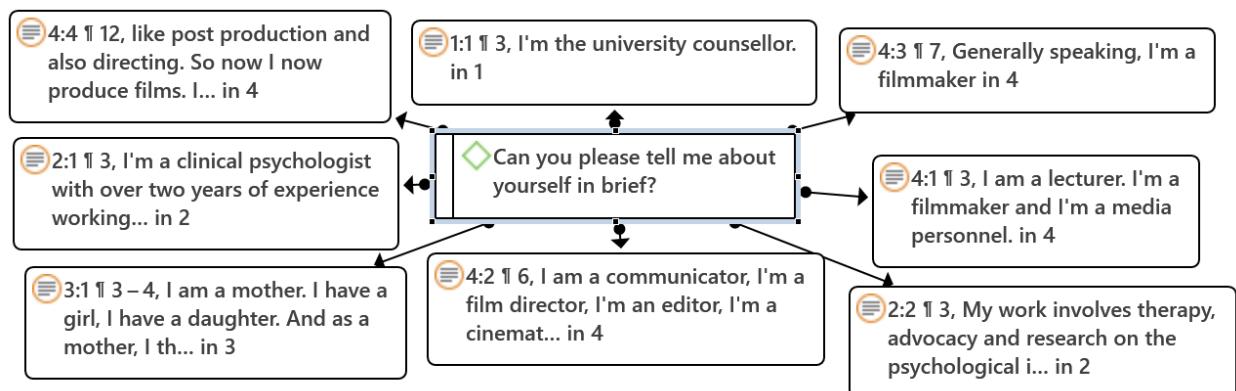


Fig 1: Can you please tell me about yourself in brief?

The diagram presents different individuals’ responses to the question, “*Can you please tell me about yourself in brief?*” The answers reflect a variety of professional backgrounds, personal experiences, and roles.

Several respondents identify with the filmmaking and media industry. One person states, *“Generally speaking, I’m a filmmaker,”* while another expands on this by saying, *“I am a lecturer. I’m a filmmaker and I’m a media personnel.”* A third respondent highlights multiple creative roles: *“I am a communicator, a film director, an editor, a cinematographer.”* Another details their involvement in the craft, mentioning skills *“like post production and also directing”* and adding, *“I teach students on how to make films.”*

Others work in psychology and counselling. One respondent says simply, *“I’m the university counsellor,”* while another shares more specific expertise: *“I’m a clinical psychologist with over two years of experience working with survivors of trauma, particularly children and adolescents who have experienced abuse.”* A related response emphasizes the applied nature of this work: *“My work involves therapy, advocacy and research on the psychological impacts of abuse and how best to support recovery and residency.”*

Personal life also plays a significant role in some responses. One participant focuses on their identity as a parent: *“I am a mother. I have a girl, I have a daughter.”* They elaborate on their motivation, explaining that they take their daughter’s well-being and development *“very, very serious”* and strive to stay informed on issues related to *“safety, health, and education.”*

Overall, the diagram illustrates a blend of creative professions, counselling and psychological expertise, and personal commitments, showing how individuals frame their identities through both professional and personal lenses.

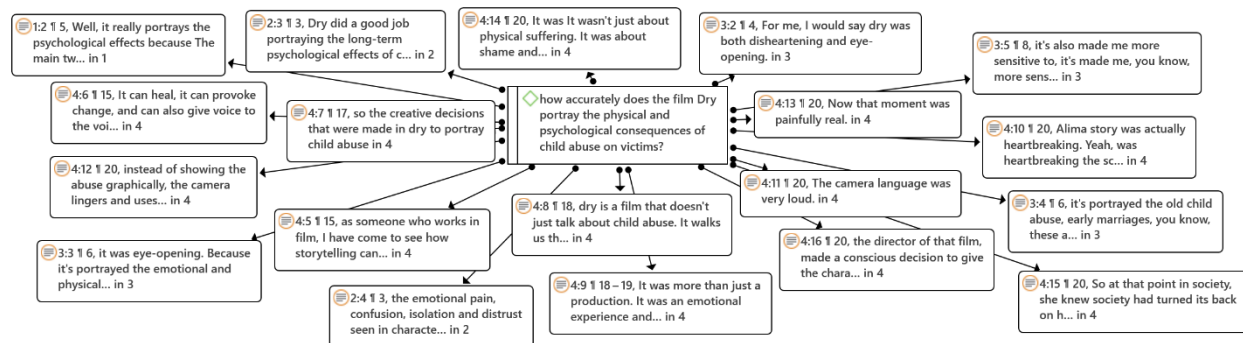


Fig 2: How accurately does the film *Dry* portray the physical and psychological consequences of child abuse on victims?

The diagram presents various perspectives on how the film *Dry* portrays the physical and psychological consequences of child abuse on victims. Many respondents emphasized the film’s ability to realistically and powerfully capture the trauma and pain associated with such abuse. One noted that it was “eye-opening” because it portrayed “the emotional and physical trauma that these girls go through in a very, very real way.” Another highlighted how it showed “old child abuse, early marriages... things that we don’t have enough awareness on,” especially in communities where such harmful traditions are still prevalent.

The film’s strength lies in depicting not only the immediate suffering but also the long-term psychological effects of abuse. As one response put it, “the main two characters in that film went through psychological trauma and emotional trauma,” while another observed that it was “about shame and how the society turns its back on victims.” This societal neglect was central to the story, with one particularly poignant point noting how a character “was full of guilt, full of shame, which could actually lead someone to depression and then to committing suicide.”

Several participants praised the film’s creative and storytelling choices in bringing these issues to light. Rather than relying on graphic depictions of abuse, the filmmakers chose to focus on “the

emotions, aftermath, the isolation, the pain and the humiliation,” allowing the audience to feel the depth of suffering in a more personal way. A specific example given was the scene where Halimah walks through a village with wet clothes, symbolizing her trauma—a moment described as “very, very, very deep.”

From a cinematic perspective, the film’s “camera language was very loud,” using silence, reaction shots, and dignified portrayals to convey realism. One person pointed out that the director consciously allowed “the child characters to exist as children, not just as victims,” giving them space to breathe as human beings rather than statistics. This approach made the story “more than just a production... an emotional experience and a call to action.”

Overall, *Dry* is seen as a film that “doesn’t just talk about child abuse” but instead walks the audience “through the reality, pain and hope of a girl or girls who are often forgotten.” It is described as both “disheartening and eye-opening,” with the potential to “heal, provoke change, and give voice to the voiceless.” Through its sensitive storytelling, it reflects the confusion, isolation, and distrust that mirror real-life patterns seen in many abuse survivors, making it a deeply moving and socially important work.

Do you want me to also restructure this interpretation into a more formal analytical essay style? That could make it flow even more cohesively.

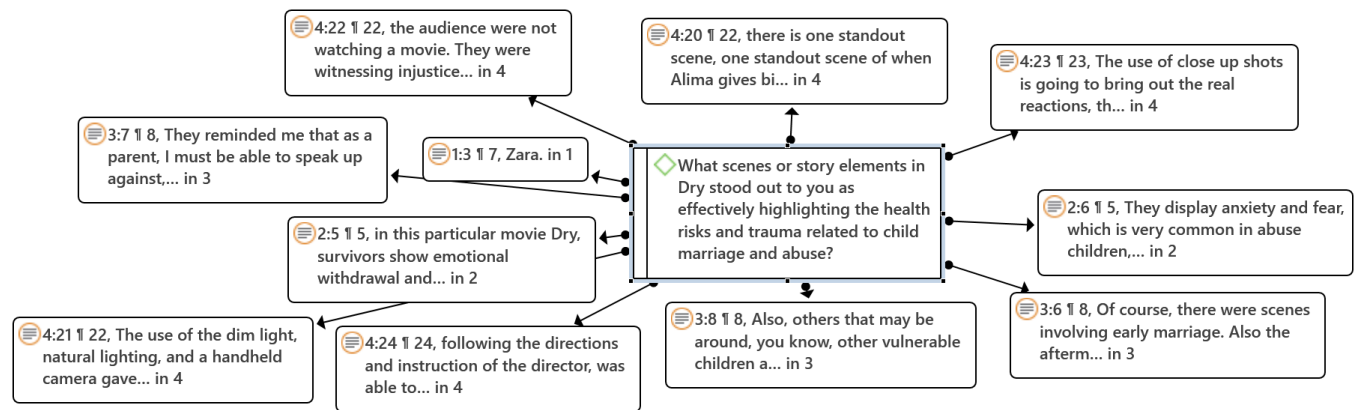


Fig 3: What scenes or story elements in *Dry* stood out to you as effectively highlighting the health risks and trauma related to child marriage and abuse?

The diagram presents various reflections on scenes from the movie *Dry* that effectively highlight the health risks and trauma related to child marriage and abuse. One particularly striking moment is described as “one standout scene, one standout scene of when Alima gives birth on the floor, alone in silence,” which clearly portrays the physical and emotional isolation that victims often face. The visual techniques used in the film, such as “the use of close-up shots” that capture “the real emotions you’re supposed to portray, the contoured in pain and fear,” immerse viewers directly into the character’s suffering. Similarly, “the use of dim light, natural lighting, and a handheld camera” gave the scenes “a raw documentary feel,” further intensifying the sense of realism and immediacy.

The emotional and psychological impacts of abuse are also powerfully represented. In the film, “survivors show emotional withdrawal and detachment,” reflecting “real-life trauma responses.” This aligns with portrayals of characters who “display anxiety and fear, which is very common in abused children,” accompanied by “feelings of shame and low self-esteem” similar to what is

observed in therapy. These depictions resonate deeply with viewers, making them feel as though “the audience were not watching a movie. They were witnessing injustice.”

Beyond the technical and narrative elements, the film also inspires personal reflection. One viewer noted, “They reminded me that as a parent, I must be able to speak up against harmful practices and protect mentally my children.” Another stressed the communal responsibility to protect the vulnerable: “It’s the duty of elders... to take care of the little ones around them, whether they’re children or not.” Such responses suggest that the movie not only communicates the dangers of child marriage but also motivates action against it.

Finally, the role of the director is acknowledged in weaving together symbolic elements and recurring motifs to reinforce the film’s message, as “following the directions and instruction of the director... some symbolism played some major rules to the recurring dry.” These creative decisions, coupled with authentic performances and cinematic techniques, contribute to a powerful narrative that brings the health risks and trauma of child marriage into stark relief.

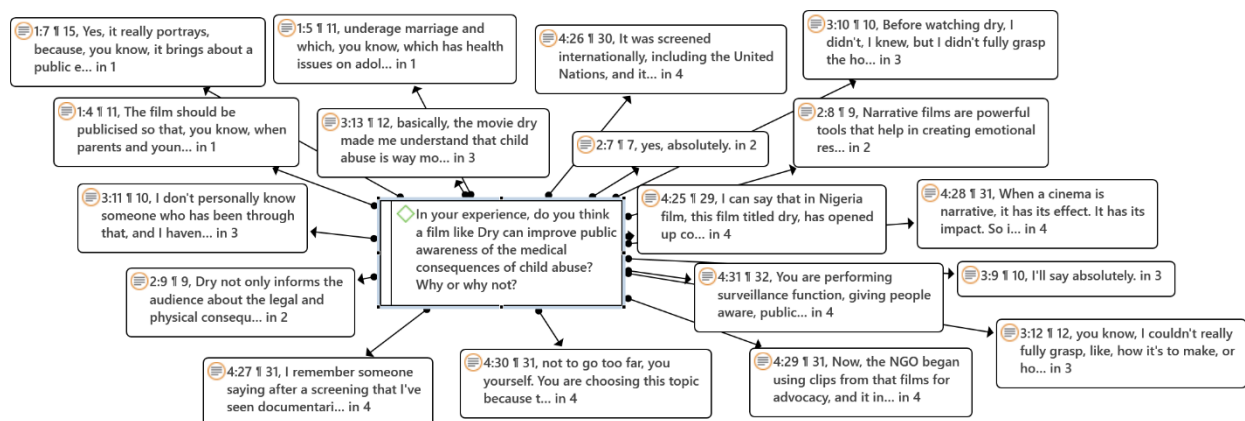


Fig 4: In your experience, do you think a film like Dry can improve public awareness of the medical consequences of child abuse? Why or Why not?

The diagram captures perspectives on how the film *Dry* can improve public awareness of the medical consequences of child abuse and early marriage. Many respondents believe the movie is a powerful tool for public enlightenment, as it “brings about a public enlightenment about... marrying an underage [child]... the health effects, [and] the psychological effects of that on them.” The film not only addresses the physical consequences of child marriage, such as “health issues on adolescents,” but also explores the deeper emotional and systemic aspects. As one person noted, *Dry* made them understand that “child abuse is way more than physical, [it] is more emotional... and systemic.”

Several viewers reflected on their personal learning experiences, admitting that before watching the film, they “didn’t fully grasp... how deep the trauma of early marriage can be,” or “how traumatic... old sexual abuse, early marriage could actually be.” The narrative approach of the film appears to have a profound effect on audiences, with some describing it as capable of making them “cry and act well,” which they attribute to “the power of a narrative cinema.” This emotional impact is seen as an effective way to raise awareness, as “narrative films are powerful tools that help in creating emotional responses and social awareness.”

The film’s influence extends beyond individual viewers to wider societal discussions. It was “screened internationally... and inspired discussions about child marriage and... fistula,” and in Nigeria, it “opened up conversations in different homes, schools and even in government offices.” NGOs have also used clips from the film for advocacy, leading to “public debates, policy discussions and even medical outreach in northern Nigeria.” These examples show that *Dry* functions not only as a piece of art but as part of a broader social campaign.

From a media studies perspective, the film performs a “surveillance function,” making people aware of “a lot of stuff that are actually not right.” By dramatizing real issues, it “allows the public [to] understand what people are going through... an eye opener,” serving as a reference point for ongoing advocacy and education. As one suggestion emphasized, it “should be publicised so that... parents and young adults... watch the film... it’s a form of information and awareness.” In short, *Dry* succeeds in transforming a sensitive topic into a catalyst for emotional engagement, informed debate, and concrete social action.

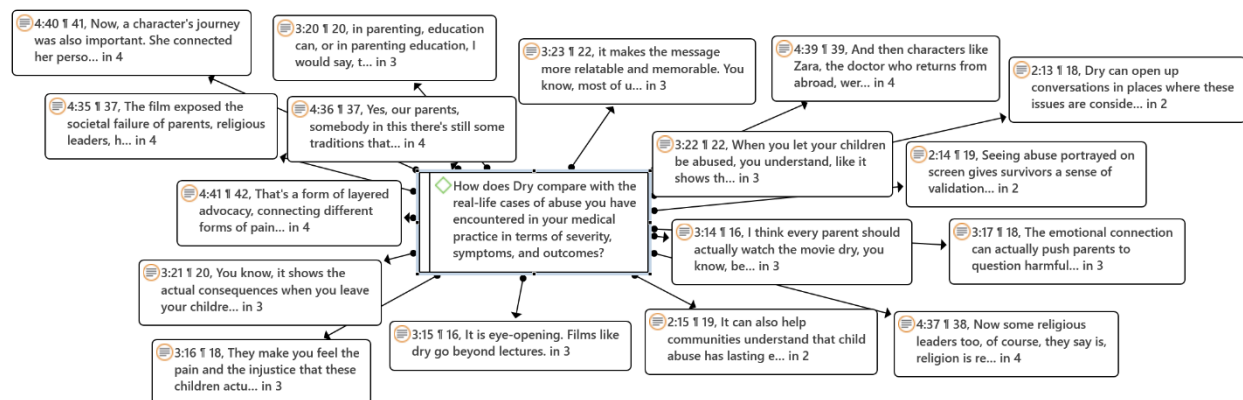


Fig 5: How does *Dry* compare with the real-life-cases of abuse you have encountered in your medical practice in terms of severity, symptoms, and outcomes?

The diagram presents various perspectives on how the movie *Dry* compares to real-life cases of abuse, particularly in the context of medical practice, focusing on severity, symptoms, and outcomes. Many respondents emphasize that the film’s portrayal of abuse resonates deeply because it mirrors the real-life consequences of neglect and harmful traditions. For instance, one observation highlights that “*in parenting, education can, or in parenting education, they can show real consequences of neglect or abuse*” and “*it shows the actual consequences when you*

leave your children.” These insights stress that the film does more than entertain—it educates and warns against the dangers of inaction.

Several participants pointed out that *Dry* makes its message relatable and memorable. As one noted, *“most of us never forget the movies which we’ve watched,”* underscoring how visual storytelling can leave a lasting impact. This emotional connection can drive change, with a respondent stating, *“The emotional connection can actually push parents to question harmful beliefs and take actions to actually protect their children.”* This transformative effect is further reinforced by another participant who admitted initial skepticism but later concluded, *“every parent should actually watch this movie.”*

The film also provides survivors with a sense of recognition. As one person shared, *“Seeing abuse portrayed on screen gives survivors a sense of validation and visibility.”* This not only acknowledges their suffering but also prompts broader societal conversations, with one comment noting that *Dry* can *“open up conversations in places where these issues are considerable.”*

Beyond individual cases, *Dry* shines a light on systemic failures. It *“exposed the societal failure of parents, religious leaders, healthcare providers and legal systems”* and portrayed how communities can perpetuate abuse. This point is illustrated by a statement pointing out that *“it wasn’t just about the abuser. It was also about the community that allowed abuse to happen, a system that allowed that abuse to happen.”* The persistence of harmful traditions was also criticized, with one remarking, *“there’s still some traditions that are still backward in nature... and they still do those kind of customs.”*

Characters in the film serve as catalysts for change. For example, Zara, a doctor who returns from abroad, was “*created to represent hope and change,*” showing that individual action can inspire societal transformation. The film also uses *layered advocacy*—as one person described—by “*connecting different forms of pain and showing the ripple effect of healing.*”

Overall, *Dry* is portrayed as more than just a movie—it is an eye-opening and emotionally charged tool that not only depicts the harsh realities of abuse but also challenges audiences to reflect, change harmful traditions, and address systemic enablers of abuse.

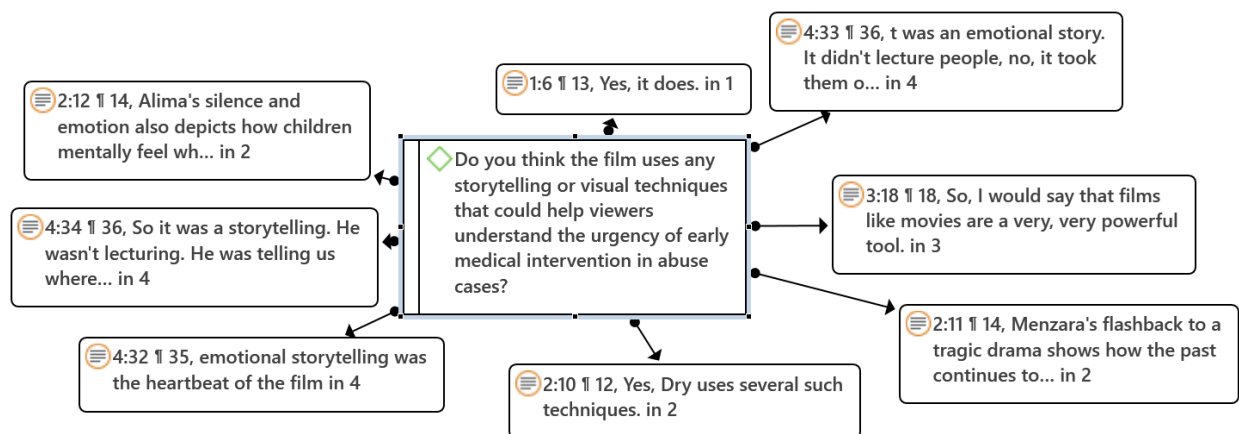


Fig 6: Do you think the film uses any storytelling or visual techniques that could help viewers understand the urgency of early medical intervention in abuse cases?

The diagram presents different perspectives on whether the film *Dry* uses storytelling or visual techniques that help viewers grasp the urgency of early medical intervention in abuse cases. Respondents widely agree that the film employs such techniques effectively. One participant noted, “*Yes, it does,*” while another emphasized, “*Yes, Dry uses several such techniques.*”

A recurring point is that the film communicates its message through emotional storytelling rather than lectures. For example, one response describes it as “*an emotional story*” that “*took us on a journey... following Halima, from innocence, to the abuse, to the rejection, to healing,*” which drew viewers into the characters’ emotional experiences. This narrative approach made the message more relatable and impactful. Another respondent supported this by saying, “*He wasn’t lecturing. He was telling us where and we were following through with it,*” underscoring the effectiveness of guiding viewers through a lived experience rather than delivering direct instruction.

Visual and emotional elements in the film also portray the psychological effects of trauma. One example is how “*Alima’s silence and emotion... depicts how children mentally feel when they are unable to process trauma.*” Similarly, “*Menzara’s flashback to a tragic drama*” illustrates how past abuse continues to impact a survivor, aligning with symptoms of PTSD. These moments offer viewers a realistic and empathetic understanding of abuse’s long-term consequences.

Overall, participants agree that emotional storytelling was “*the heartbeat of the film*” and that “*films like movies are a very, very powerful tool*” in raising awareness about abuse and encouraging early intervention. By weaving emotional depth, visual cues, and character-driven narratives, *Dry* delivers a compelling message that resonates more deeply than traditional informational approaches.

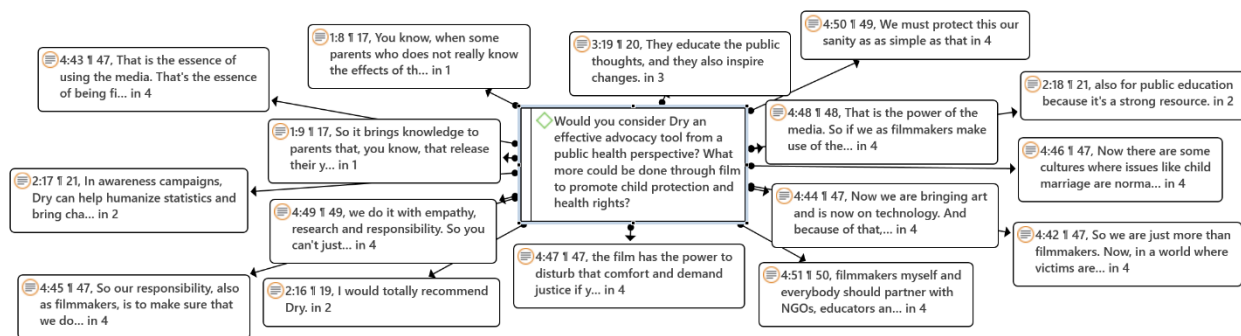


Fig 7: Would you consider Dry an effective advocacy tool from a public health perspective?

What more could be done through film to promote child protection and health rights?

The diagram illustrates perspectives on whether *Dry* serves as an effective advocacy tool from a public health standpoint, as well as how film can further promote child protection and health rights. A recurring theme is the potential of film to educate and inspire change. One view points out that “*they educate the public thoughts, and they also inspire changes,*” showing how storytelling can shift societal attitudes. Similarly, the film is seen as a means to “*bring knowledge to parents... that release their young children for marriage,*” helping them understand the negative health and psychological impacts of such practices.

Several responses highlight the broader role of media in advocacy. As one person put it, “*That is the essence of using the media. That’s the essence of being filmmakers. We use the technology.*” This sentiment is echoed in the belief that filmmakers are more than storytellers—they are also responsible for “*helping in changing, giving voice to the voiceless, especially in issues like this.*” The film’s capacity to “disturb the comfort” of harmful cultural norms is emphasized, with the assertion that “*if we make use of that will, we can actually disturb the comfort of this... useless old practices that is against human rights.*”

The participants also discuss how *Dry* can transcend geographical boundaries through technology, enabling “*people far and wide, people in diaspora... to hear the message you want to send.*” By doing so, filmmakers not only raise awareness but also empower victims in a world where “*victims are silenced.*” There is a strong emphasis on responsibility and approach, with the reminder that advocacy must be carried out “*with empathy, research and responsibility*” and should not just focus on suffering but also “*show humanity.*”

Partnerships are also considered crucial for maximizing impact. One viewpoint stresses the need for filmmakers to collaborate with NGOs, educators, and survivors to tell stories that “*don’t just entertain but enlighten and empower.*” Such partnerships are seen as the pathway to meaningful change, ensuring that advocacy through film results in tangible improvements in public health and child protection.

Overall, the responses present *Dry* as more than a work of art—it is viewed as a strategic public health communication tool capable of educating, challenging harmful norms, amplifying marginalized voices, and fostering collaborative efforts for societal change.

4.3 Discussion of Findings

Question One (RQ1): What is the representation of child abuse and rights and its consequences in *Dry* film?

The findings from the survey, interviews, and FGDs collectively reveal that the film *Dry* provides a vivid and multifaceted representation of child abuse and child rights, particularly highlighting its devastating consequences on victims.

From the survey, a majority of respondents agreed that the film realistically depicted the experiences of abused children, although some expressed reservations about the extent of accuracy. Specifically, students recognized that *Dry* captured not only the physical harm associated with child marriage but also the psychological and emotional trauma endured by victims. This perception aligns with Johnson and Eze's (2022) assertion that Nollywood dramas, especially those grounded in real-life social issues, serve as powerful mirrors of society.

The interview findings corroborate this perception. Medical professionals interviewed emphasized how the film accurately portrayed health complications such as vesico-vaginal fistula (VVF), a common consequence of early childbirth in underage marriages. Legal practitioners further observed that the film exposed systemic failures in protecting children's rights, thereby highlighting the gaps between the Child Rights Act (2003) and its enforcement. Counselors and psychologists interviewed also noted that Halima's story in *Dry* reflected the real psychological scars of abuse, including trauma, low self-esteem, and disempowerment, which are often ignored in policy discussions.

Insights from the FGDs reinforced the survey and interview results. Students in the focus groups described Halima's character as a "representation of thousands of silenced girls in Nigerian communities," pointing to the film's ability to humanize the statistics of child marriage. Participants also stressed that the emotional storytelling deepened their understanding of child abuse beyond theoretical knowledge, sparking empathy and critical reflection. This confirms the observation of Olawale and Musa (2023) that films can bridge the gap between abstract advocacy messages and lived experiences by personalizing social problems.

Theoretically, these findings can be situated within Cultivation Theory, which posits that sustained exposure to media content shapes perceptions of reality (Gerbner et al., 2021). By consistently portraying the dangers of child marriage and abuse, *Dry* cultivates a heightened awareness among its viewers, making the issue more urgent and tangible. Similarly, Social Responsibility Theory is evident in the film's deliberate focus on revealing social injustices rather than purely entertaining. Stephanie Linus's production demonstrates Nollywood's responsibility to use film as a medium of advocacy, thereby fulfilling its ethical duty to society.

In line with prior studies, the representation of child abuse in *Dry* has been shown to influence both awareness and policy debates. For example, Bamidele and Chukwuma (2022) observed that socially conscious films often serve as catalysts for legal discussions on child rights, a trend also visible in how *Dry* has been screened at advocacy and legislative sessions.

In summary, the survey, interviews, and FGDs converge on the conclusion that *Dry* represents child abuse as a deeply damaging phenomenon with long-term physical, emotional, and social consequences. The film humanizes these issues through its characters, dramatizes systemic failures, and reinforces the urgency of addressing child rights violations. However, some

divergence in student survey responses suggests that while many saw the depictions as accurate, a minority remained neutral or skeptical, indicating that film alone may not fully capture the complexities of real-life abuse without complementary education and advocacy.

Research Question Two (RQ2): What cinematic and narrative techniques does *Dry* employ to promote awareness of child rights?

The data from the survey, interviews, and FGDs highlight that *Dry* employs a combination of cinematic techniques and narrative devices—such as cinematography, character development, dialogue, and plot structure—that reinforce its advocacy on child rights.

From the survey analysis (Table 6), most students agreed that the film’s dialogue (weighted mean = 3.93) and narrative structure (3.71) were particularly effective in raising awareness of child rights. Dialogue was seen as the strongest element, as it conveyed clear moral lessons and legal realities surrounding child abuse. Character development (mean = 3.65) was also rated positively, with students recognizing that the emotional journeys of Halima and Dr. Zara humanized the abstract issue of child rights. However, cinematography (mean = 3.39) drew more divided opinions, with some respondents noting that while visuals conveyed emotion, others felt the imagery was less powerful compared to the dialogue and story.

The interviews provided a professional perspective. The media practitioner interviewed emphasized that Stephanie Linus’s storytelling technique deliberately blended realism with dramatization to achieve advocacy impact. The legal expert argued that the courtroom scenes and portrayals of legal failures were central in educating audiences about gaps in child rights enforcement. Meanwhile, the counselor and psychologist stressed that the film’s flashbacks and emotional pacing allowed audiences to connect more deeply with Halima’s trauma, a technique

that aligns with Adeleke's (2023) observation that films evoke empathy through carefully constructed narratives.

Findings from the FGDs further reinforced these points. Students highlighted the contrasting character arcs of Halima (the victim) and Dr. Zara (the advocate) as powerful narrative devices that symbolized the dual realities of vulnerability and resistance. Many participants noted that the juxtaposition of rural and urban settings in the film emphasized the structural inequalities that perpetuate child abuse. Students also appreciated the use of symbolism, such as Halima's deteriorating health, which was perceived as a metaphor for the consequences of systemic neglect.

These findings can be interpreted through Cultivation Theory and Social Responsibility Theory. Cultivation Theory explains how repeated exposure to emotionally resonant narratives influences perceptions of child rights, particularly when supported by strong character-driven storytelling (Gerbner et al., 2021). Social Responsibility Theory underscores how filmmakers have a duty to craft narratives that not only entertain but also enlighten and mobilize the public (McQuail, 2020). *Dry* demonstrates this by weaving compelling drama with advocacy messages, ensuring that audiences internalize the urgency of protecting children's rights.

Empirical evidence from Johnson and Eze (2022) supports these findings, as their study on *Dry* revealed that its narrative depth and emotional framing significantly influenced audience understanding of child marriage. Similarly, Olawale and Musa (2023) note that socially conscious films use narrative realism as a strategy to shift cultural attitudes toward harmful practices.

In summary, the survey, interviews, and FGDs converge on the finding that *Dry*'s most effective cinematic and narrative techniques are its dialogue, character development, and story structure. These elements combined to humanize victims, dramatize consequences, and clarify the

importance of child rights. Although some students were less convinced about the strength of its cinematography, the consensus across analyses is that *Dry* uses narrative and cinematic tools strategically to promote awareness and mobilize social change.

Research Question Three (RQ3): In what ways has the film *Dry* influenced public awareness and understanding of child abuse?

The findings from the survey, interviews, and FGDs consistently indicate that *Dry* has had a strong influence on raising public awareness and improving understanding of child abuse, though the degree of influence varies among audiences.

From the survey (Table 7), a majority of students affirmed that *Dry* increased awareness of child abuse (mean = 3.79) and enhanced understanding (mean = 3.55). Similarly, 70.8% agreed or strongly agreed that the film contributed to greater recognition of the importance of addressing child abuse. However, the relatively high neutral responses (36.2% undecided about whether the film raised awareness) suggest that while the film was impactful, not all students were equally persuaded, pointing to the need for complementary advocacy and education programs.

The interview data provided more nuanced insights. The medical practitioner noted that the film expanded awareness about the health consequences of child marriage, especially obstetric fistula, which many viewers had little knowledge of prior to watching the film. The educationist and sociologist argued that *Dry*'s role in stimulating discussions within classrooms and policy circles has been significant, as it provides an accessible entry point into complex social issues. Meanwhile, the legal practitioner highlighted how the film has been referenced in awareness campaigns and even legislative sessions, reinforcing Bamidele and Chukwuma's (2022) finding that films often serve as bridges between public opinion and policy action.

Insights from the FGDs reveal that students felt personally affected by the film's messages. Participants described becoming "more conscious" of the prevalence of child marriage and its impact on girls' futures. Many also reported that the film changed their attitudes from passive awareness to active concern, motivating them to engage in conversations about child rights with peers and family. However, some participants noted that while the film was eye-opening, its impact could fade without follow-up advocacy, a point supported by Olawale and Musa (2024), who argue that films require reinforcement through community engagement to achieve long-term influence.

From a theoretical perspective, Cultivation Theory explains how repeated exposure to *Dry* and similar films helps cultivate a heightened sense of urgency about child abuse. Students who had watched the film more than once reported deeper awareness and understanding, underscoring Gerbner's view that cumulative media exposure shapes social consciousness. Meanwhile, Social Responsibility Theory situates *Dry* as a socially responsible production that prioritizes advocacy over profit, deliberately using storytelling to inform the public about rights violations and stimulate societal discourse (McQuail, 2020).

Empirical studies reinforce these findings. Johnson and Eze (2022) reported that *Dry* significantly deepened audience knowledge of the psychological and medical consequences of child marriage. Similarly, Adeleke (2023) demonstrated that films evoke empathy and moral reflection, which in turn fosters stronger public awareness and action.

In summary, the survey, interviews, and FGDs converge on the conclusion that *Dry* has been effective in increasing public awareness and understanding of child abuse by exposing its health, psychological, and social consequences. The film not only educates but also motivates audiences

to discuss and reconsider cultural norms surrounding child marriage. Nonetheless, the presence of neutral responses and some skepticism suggests that awareness created through film alone may not be sufficient; sustained advocacy efforts are needed to reinforce and translate awareness into action.

Research Question Four (RQ4): What advocacy styles or approaches are utilized in *Dry* to address child abuse and promote child rights?

The analysis of survey, interview, and FGD data shows that *Dry* employs a range of advocacy strategies emotional appeal, realistic portrayal, narrative framing, and calls to action—that reinforce its role as a tool for social change.

From the survey (Table 8), most students agreed that the film’s advocacy approach was effective, with the strongest support for its realistic portrayal of child abuse (mean = 3.80) and its ability to promote action against abuse (mean = 3.86). Emotional appeal also recorded support (mean = 3.40), though opinions were more divided, with 17.7% strongly disagreeing. This indicates that while many viewers found the film’s advocacy compelling, a minority felt its emotional dramatization was either excessive or less convincing. Overall, the weighted mean (3.73) reflects general approval of the advocacy strategies deployed in the film.

The interviews provided more depth. The media practitioner noted that the film’s use of emotional appeal especially through Halima’s tragic story—was deliberate, intended to humanize statistics and provoke empathy. The counselor and psychologist emphasized that portraying trauma and its long-term psychological effects was key to motivating audiences to consider the seriousness of child abuse. Legal experts pointed out that the advocacy was not just emotional but also institutional, as the film highlighted gaps in law enforcement and indirectly called for stronger

implementation of the Child Rights Act (2003). The educationist described the film as a “pedagogical resource,” since its advocacy approach made it suitable for teaching about child rights in academic settings.

The FGDs reinforced these findings, with students recognizing *Dry*’s blend of advocacy strategies. Participants described the film’s emotional storytelling as “unforgettable,” while also noting that its call to action was implicit rather than explicit—viewers were left with a sense of moral duty to challenge harmful practices in their communities. Some students felt that the advocacy was effective because it combined individual narratives (Halima and Dr. Zara) with broader social commentary, thereby connecting personal tragedy with systemic change.

Theoretically, these findings resonate with Social Responsibility Theory, which emphasizes the ethical obligation of media to serve public interest by promoting social justice (McQuail, 2020). *Dry* embodies this by using its narrative as a platform for advocacy rather than mere entertainment. Likewise, Cultivation Theory helps explain how repeated exposure to emotionally charged advocacy in film can shape societal attitudes, reinforcing empathy and motivating action (Gerbner et al., 2021).

In the broader literature, Linus (2021) emphasized that *Dry* was intentionally designed as an advocacy film to spark conversations on child marriage and mobilize action. Bamidele and Chukwuma (2022) also found that advocacy films act as bridges between public consciousness and policymaking, a role that *Dry* has fulfilled by being used in community sensitization and legislative debates.

In summary, the film *Dry* utilizes a multifaceted advocacy approach that combines emotional appeal, realism, narrative depth, and implicit calls to action. While some viewers were less

persuaded by the emotional dramatization, the majority of students, professionals, and focus group participants found the advocacy compelling and effective. By blending personal stories

With systemic critique, the film encourages audiences to empathize, reflect, and engage in efforts to protect children's rights.

CHAPTER FIVE

SUMMARY, CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Summary

This study set out to examine the role of film in addressing child abuse and promoting child rights, with a special focus on Stephanie Linus's *Dry*. The findings, drawn from surveys, interviews, and focus group discussions, converge on four key insights.

First, the representation of child abuse in *Dry* was widely perceived as realistic and impactful. Students, professionals, and focus group participants agreed that the film vividly captured the physical, emotional, and psychological consequences of child marriage and abuse. Although a minority of survey respondents expressed skepticism about the extent of realism, the consensus was that the film humanized the struggles of victims and dramatized the failures of societal and legal systems to protect children.

Second, the study found that *Dry* employs powerful cinematic and narrative techniques—including dialogue, character development, and narrative structure—that enhanced its advocacy impact. Survey data highlighted dialogue as the most effective element, while professionals emphasized the role of character arcs and plot design in humanizing the abuse narrative. Focus group participants particularly appreciated the film's symbolic contrasts, such as rural–urban inequalities, which emphasized the systemic nature of abuse.

Third, the findings show that *Dry* significantly influenced public awareness and understanding of child abuse. Survey results indicated that most respondents became more conscious of the seriousness of child abuse and its long-term consequences after watching the film. Professionals confirmed that the film has been used in classrooms, advocacy campaigns, and policy discussions

to stimulate awareness. FGD participants noted that the film moved them from passive awareness to active concern, although some emphasized that reinforcement through continued advocacy is necessary for sustained impact.

Finally, the study established that *Dry* adopts multifaceted advocacy approaches. These include emotional appeal, realistic portrayals of abuse, and implicit calls to action. Survey results confirmed general agreement on the effectiveness of these strategies, while interviews and FGDs revealed that audiences found the advocacy compelling because it combined personal stories with systemic critique. The film was seen as not only evoking empathy but also motivating reflection and dialogue on child rights.

Overall, the study confirms that *Dry* exemplifies Nollywood's potential to serve as a tool for social responsibility and cultural transformation. While some viewers questioned aspects of its accuracy or dramatization, the combined analyses demonstrate that the film successfully represented abuse, employed strong narrative tools, influenced awareness, and advanced advocacy for child rights.

5.2 Conclusion

This study examined the role of Nollywood films in addressing child abuse and promoting child rights, using Stephanie Linus's *Dry* as a case study. The findings from the survey, interviews, and focus group discussions demonstrate that films are powerful advocacy tools capable of shaping perceptions, raising awareness, and stimulating public discourse on sensitive social issues.

The results showed that *Dry* realistically represented the physical, psychological, and social consequences of child abuse, particularly through the story of Halima, who symbolized the

experiences of many young girls subjected to child marriage. This realistic portrayal resonated with audiences, fostering empathy and critical reflection.

The study also established that the film's narrative and cinematic techniques—especially dialogue, character development, and plot structure—were central to its effectiveness in raising awareness. These elements helped humanize victims and highlight systemic failures, thereby transforming abstract advocacy into relatable storytelling.

In terms of impact, *Dry* was found to significantly increase awareness and understanding of child abuse among its audiences. The film inspired deeper conversations in classrooms, communities, and policy circles, confirming the arguments of Cultivation Theory that repeated media exposure influences social perceptions. Moreover, the film reflects the principles of Social Responsibility Theory, as it fulfills Nollywood's ethical obligation to use media for social good by prioritizing advocacy over mere entertainment.

Finally, the film employed a multifaceted advocacy approach, blending emotional appeal, realism, and calls to action. While some viewers found the emotional dramatization excessive, the majority regarded the advocacy style as compelling and effective in promoting reflection and action against child abuse.

In conclusion, the study affirms that films such as *Dry* can bridge the gap between public awareness and policy advocacy, contributing meaningfully to the fight against child abuse and the promotion of child rights in Nigeria. However, the findings also suggest that for films to achieve sustained impact, they must be supported by continuous advocacy, educational interventions, and policy enforcement.

5.3 Recommendations

1. Policymakers and advocacy groups should encourage the production of more films that vividly portray the realities of child abuse. By supporting content that reflects lived experiences, films can continue to humanize victims and challenge harmful cultural practices. Partnerships between filmmakers and child protection agencies can ensure that representations are accurate and impactful.
2. Filmmakers should deliberately adopt narrative devices—such as strong character development, relatable dialogue, and symbolic storytelling—that resonate with audiences while advancing advocacy. Training workshops for Nollywood practitioners could enhance their capacity to integrate social issues into compelling narratives without sacrificing artistic quality.
3. Educational institutions and civil society organizations should incorporate films like *Dry* into awareness campaigns, school curricula, and community dialogues. This will reinforce learning, bridge knowledge gaps, and sustain awareness, especially among young people who are more impressionable and likely to advocate for change.
4. To strengthen advocacy, Nollywood producers should combine emotional appeal with factual information and provide viewers with actionable steps—such as contacts for support services or references to relevant laws. This will help translate empathy into concrete action. Additionally, screenings of advocacy films should be accompanied by guided discussions to maximize their influence.

5.4 Limitations of the Study

While this study has provided valuable insights into the role of film in addressing child abuse and promoting child rights, it is not without limitations. First, the research focused on a single Nollywood film, *Dry*, which, although significant, cannot fully capture the diversity of approaches that other films may take in addressing similar social issues. This narrow scope limits the generalizability of the findings to Nollywood as a whole.

Second, the sample size was restricted to undergraduate students in one private university and a small number of professionals from selected fields. Although the perspectives gathered were rich and informative, they may not fully represent the broader Nigerian population, particularly rural communities where child marriage and abuse are more prevalent.

Third, the reliance on self-reported data from surveys, interviews, and focus group discussions may have introduced some degree of bias. Respondents may have provided socially desirable answers, especially on sensitive issues like child abuse, which could have influenced the findings.

Finally, while the study highlighted the film's impact on awareness and advocacy, it did not measure long-term behavioral change among audiences. As suggested by previous studies (Olawale & Musa, 2024), the impact of films tends to diminish without sustained advocacy, a dimension that could not be fully explored within the scope of this research.

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APPENDIX I

QUESTIONNAIRE

Title:

The role of film in addressing child abuse and promoting child rights, with a special focus on the film Dry

Introduction:

Dear Respondent,

I am Oyediran Dolapo a postgraduate student of KolaDaisi University, Department of Mass communication conducting a research project on the role of film in addressing child abuse and promoting child rights, with a special focus on the film Dry. Your responses will be kept confidential and used strictly for academic purposes. Kindly answer honestly.

Thank you.

Section A: Demographic Information

Please tick (✓) the appropriate option.

1. Gender: Male () (Female)
2. Age: Below 15 years () **16-20 years ()** 21– 25years () 26 years and above ()
3. Faculty: FAMS () FBMS () FAPS () FLAW ()
4. Level: 100 () 200 () 300 () 400 () 500 ()

SECTION: B Respondents familiarity with the film and its themes, and understand respondents' initial perceptions of the film's relevance.

5. Have you watched the film "Dry" before?
 - ☐ Yes
 - ☐ No
6. How familiar are you with the themes of child abuse and child rights?
 - ☐ Not familiar
 - ☐ Somewhat familiar
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Familiar
 - ☐ Very familiar
7. How relevant do you think the film "Dry" is to the issue of child abuse and child rights?
 - ☐ Not relevant
 - ☐ Somewhat relevant
 - ☐ Neutral
 - ☐ Relevant
 - ☐ Very relevant

SECTION: C What is your rating of the following statements with regard to your perception about the representation of child abuse and rights and its consequences in DRY film.?Use the following scale: **1 = Strongly Disagree (SD) 2 = Disagree (D) 3 = Not Sure (N) 4 = Agree (A) and 5 = Strongly Agree (SA)**

S/N	ITEMS	SD 1	D 2	N 3	A 4	SA 5
8	The film "Dry" accurately portrays the experiences of children who have suffered abuse.					
9	The film effectively raises awareness about the importance of child rights.					
10	The consequences of child abuse are realistically depicted in the film.					
11	The film "Dry" encourages viewers to take action to prevent child abuse.					

SECTION: D What is your rating of the following statements with regard to the usage of cinematic and narrative techniques to promote awareness of child rights in the film Dry? Use the following scale: **1 = Strongly Disagree (SD) 2 = Disagree (D) 3 = Not Sure (N) 4 = Agree (A) and 5 = Strongly Agree (SA)**

S/N	ITEMS	SD 1	D 2	N 3	A 4	SA 5
12	The film's use of cinematography effectively conveys the emotional impact of child abuse.					
13	The film's use of character development effectively humanises the experiences of children affected by abuse.					
14	The narrative structure of the film helps to raise awareness about child rights issues.					
15	The dialogue in the film effectively conveys the importance of child rights.					

SECTION: E What is your rating of the following statements with regard to the ways the film Dry influenced public awareness and understanding of child abuse? : **1 = Strongly Disagree (SD)**
2 = Disagree (D) **3 = Not Sure (N)** **4 = Agree (A)** and **5 = Strongly Agree (SA)**

S/N	ITEMS	SD 1	D 2	N 3	A 4	SA 5
16	The film "Dry" has increased public awareness of child abuse.					
17	Dry" has effectively promoted a better understanding of child abuse among audiences.					
18	The film "Dry" has contributed to a greater recognition of the importance of addressing child abuse.					

SECTION: F What is your rating of the following statements with regard to the advocacy styles or approaches utilized in Dry to address child abuse and promote child rights: **1 = Strongly Disagree (SD)** **2 = Disagree (D)** **3 = Not Sure (N)** **4 = Agree (A)** and **5 = Strongly Agree (SA)**

S/ N	ITEMS	SD 1	D 2	N 3	A 4	SA 5
19.	The film "Dry" uses emotional appeal to raise awareness about child abuse.					
20.	The film's narrative effectively highlights the importance of child rights.					
21.	Dry" employs a realistic portrayal of child abuse to promote empathy and understanding.					
22.	The film's advocacy approach is effective in promoting action against child abuse.					

Thank you for your participation!

APPENDIX II

Interview Guide

Opening statement

Thank you for participating in this interview and sharing your experience and thoughts. The interview will be audio recorded but conversation will be kept confidential. The purpose of the interview is to carry out research on *Exploring the role of film in addressing child abuse and rights: A study of Dry Film*. If you feel not to answer any question you can mention. You are also free to stop your participation in the interview at any particular time during the process.

1. Can you please tell me about yourself in brief?
2. From a medical standpoint, how accurately does the film *Dry* portray the physical and psychological consequences of child abuse on victims?
3. What scenes or story elements in *Dry* stood out to you as effectively highlighting the health risks and trauma related to child marriage and abuse?
4. In your experience, do you think a film like *Dry* can improve public awareness of the medical consequences of child abuse? Why or why not?
5. How does *Dry* compare with the real-life cases of abuse you have encountered in your medical practice in terms of severity, symptoms, and outcomes?
6. Do you think the film uses any storytelling or visual techniques that could help viewers understand the urgency of early medical intervention in abuse cases?
7. Would you consider *Dry* an effective advocacy tool from a public health perspective? What more could be done through film to promote child protection and health rights?
8. Is there any information inform of materials you are willing to give to enhance this study?
9. If I need to ask anything more, is it possible for you that I visit again?

Thank you sir/ma, for your time and participation.

APPENDIX III

Focus Group Discussion Instrument

Exploring the Role of Film in Addressing Child Abuse and Rights: A Case Study of *Dry*

1. How did you feel about the way *Dry* portrayed child abuse and the challenges some children, especially girls, face in society?
2. Were there any scenes, characters, or situations in the film that felt very real or familiar to things you've seen or heard in your own environment?
3. What storytelling techniques in *Dry* caught your attention like the music, flashbacks, emotions, or setting and how did they help you understand the message?
4. Do you think *Dry* helped you learn more about child rights and the problems of early marriage, abuse, or neglect? Why or why not?
5. If you had to explain the main advocacy message of *Dry* to someone who hasn't watched it, what would you say the film is trying to change in society?
6. What do you think students and young people can do to help prevent child abuse and promote child rights, especially after watching a film like *Dry*?